

CITY: Pg 3

Safety bell rings across 5,633 schools



NATION: Pg 5

Ram temple donation row exposed power struggle within BJP: Akhilesh



FILM: Pg 12

Diljit Dosanjh's 'not shocked' after 'Satlu' removed from OTT



RAM TEMPLE DONATION ROW

Trust accepts resignations, names interim chief, launches CEO search

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

AYODHYA: The Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust on Monday accepted the resignations of general secretary Champat Rai and trustee Anil Mishra amid the ongoing investigation into the alleged embezzlement of devotees' donations at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya. The Trust also appointed senior trustee Krishna Mohan as interim general secretary, announced a three-member committee to identify a chief executive officer (CEO) for the temple trust, and said it would overhaul its donation management system as it seeks to restore public confidence ahead of the Special Investigation Team's (SIT) final report expected later this month.

The decisions were taken during a more than three-hour meeting chaired by Trust president Mahant Nritya Gopal Das at the Ram Janmabhoomi complex. According to sources, extraordinary secrecy was



Ram Temple Trust displays items donated by devotees to the temple during an interaction with media, in Ayodhya, on Monday

maintained during the deliberations. No security personnel were allowed inside the meeting room and all participants deposited their

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Trust formed a three-member panel to identify a CEO
- » Donation management system will be overhauled
- » SIT probing alleged theft of crores in devotees' donations
- » Investigators suspect cash was stolen nearly 70 times over 40 days
- » Eight people, including Rai's driver, have been arrested so far
- » No trustee has been named in the FIR, Trust clarified
- » Trust expects SIT's final report before July 22 meeting
- » Trust said all 2,926 non cash offerings remain safe and fully documented

mobile phones before entering. Of the Trust's 15 members, nine attended in person while two joined virtually.

Continued on P4

KRISHNA MOHAN: THE RETIRED IFS OFFICER NOW LEADING THE RAM TEMPLE TRUST

AYODHYA: Krishna Mohan, the newly appointed interim general secretary of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust, is a retired Indian Forest Service (IFS) officer and a senior functionary associated with the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS). He has been given the additional charge of the Trust's top executive post following the resignation of Champat Rai amid the ongoing donation embezzlement investigation.

A 1978-batch IFS officer of the Maharashtra cadre, Krishna Mohan holds a Master's degree in Science from Lucknow University and is originally from Hardoi district in Uttar Pradesh. After retirement, he remained active in social and organisational work.

Krishna Mohan was inducted into the 15-member Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust in 2025 following the death of trustee Kameshwar Chaupal. His appointment maintained representation from the same social community as Chaupal. Before becoming a trustee, he was associated with the Trust's activities and participated in meetings relating to the Ram temple project.

Monsoon unleashes havoc across India, Maha at epicentre of crisis



13 dead so far, 'Missing Link' fails 1st rain test

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Relentless monsoon rain battered large parts of India on Monday, leaving a trail of deaths, floods, landslides and transport disruptions across several states. Maharashtra witnessed the worst impact, with

three more rain-related deaths in Pune taking the state's toll to 13 over the past three to four days. Himachal Pradesh reported the death of a 14-year-old girl after she was struck by falling rocks, while flash floods and landslides damaged roads and infrastructure in Jammu

and Kashmir. Odisha remained on high alert as continuous rain flooded towns and disrupted daily life, while Delhi, despite receiving little rain, endured severe humidity with "feel-like" temperatures approaching 50 degrees Celsius.

Continued on P4



Nitin Nabin abandoned Bankipur at first opportunity  
Prashant Kishor

In today's paper

CITY

TERROR PLOT FOILED 2

NATION

COOPERATION MINISTRY COMPLETES 5 YRS 5

EDIT

POWER ENTERS THE PITCH 7

INTERNATIONAL

MACRON VISITS SYRIA 8

BUSINESS

MARKETS RISE TO 2-MONTH HIGH 10

SPORT

3RD T20I: INDIA SEEK REBOUND 11

Long-term strategic ties to dominate PM's Indonesia visit

Arrives in Indonesia to further strengthen India's Act East Policy

VINAY KUMAR

JAKARTA: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Monday arrived in Indonesia for the first leg of his three-nation tour, aimed at further strengthening India's Act East Policy, MAHASAGAR Vision, and its commitment to a free, open, and inclusive Indo-Pacific.

In a special gesture, PM Modi was received at the airport by Indonesian President Prabowo Subianto. In addition, four ministers were also present to receive the Prime Minister, who was accorded a traditional ceremonial welcome and a Guard of Honour.

"Landed in Jakarta. I'm touched by President Prabowo Subianto's gesture of welcoming me at the airport," Modi said in a social media post.



Prime Minister Narendra Modi walks with Indonesian President Prabowo Subianto at Halim Perdanakusuma Air Base in Jakarta, Indonesia

This is PM Modi's first bilateral visit to Indonesia since the elevation of ties to a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership in 2018.

Modi said he will hold discussions with President Subianto

PAHALGAM TERROR ATTACK

NIA charges LeT chief Hafiz Saeed for cross-border conspiracy

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: The National Investigation Agency (NIA) on Monday filed a supplementary chargesheet against Pakistan-based Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT) chief Hafiz Saeed in connection with the April 2025 Pahalgam terror attack, accusing him of orchestrating the conspiracy from across the border.

The supplementary chargesheet was submitted before the special NIA court in Jammu. The 76-year-old Saeed has been booked under various provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), 2023, and the Unlawful Activities (Prevention)



Act, 1967. According to the agency, he has been charged both in his personal capacity and as the head of the banned LeT and its proxy outfit, The Resistance Front (TRF).

"NIA has also invoked the

NIA HAS ALSO INVOKED THE PENAL SECTION AGAINST THE ACCUSED FOR WAGING WAR AGAINST INDIA AND HATCHING A CONSPIRACY FROM ACROSS THE BORDER IN THE CHARGESHEET

penal section against the accused for waging war against India and hatching a conspiracy from across the border in the chargesheet," the agency said in a statement.

Continued on P4

Hamas dissolves govt in Gaza, plans power transfer to UN-backed board

It did not confirm disarmament or handing over security control

ASSOCIATED PRESS

DEIR AL-BALAH (GAZA STRIP): The Hamas militant group said Monday it had dissolved its government in Gaza and is preparing to transfer power to a technical committee backed by the United Nations as part of a US-brokered ceasefire deal.

Hamas did not say whether it planned to take the crucial step of disarming or handing over security to an international force, but described its decision as evidence of its commitment to Gaza's reconstruction after years of war.

It was unclear if the move, announced by a lower-level official, would lead to any meaningful change on the ground.

The Board of Peace, the new



entity led by President Donald Trump with the mandate of governing and rebuilding Gaza, said it was aware of the Hamas announcement

but said it would assess the impact based on "actions, not promises." The board stressed in a statement on X that the technocratic committee must

control all weapons in Gaza, as laid out in the ceasefire agreement. At a news conference Monday, Ismail al-Thawabta,

Continued on P4

CLOSER LOOK

- » Hamas calls move proof of commitment to Gaza's reconstruction
- » Board of Peace says it will judge by actions, not promises
- » Board insists technocratic committee must control all weapons in Gaza
- » Hamas says only technical staff will continue running daily services
- » Israel dismisses Hamas announcement as meaningless political spin

Review cash transfer schemes for women to match inflation: PM advisory panel

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Economic Advisory Council to the Prime Minister (EAC-PM) has called for periodic reviews of unconditional cash transfer (UCT) schemes for women to ensure benefits remain adequate as inflation rises and household spending patterns change.

In a working paper released on Monday, the council said transfer amounts should be revised from time to time, with savings from better targeting used to increase benefits and support complementary services for beneficiaries.

The paper, titled Unconditional Women Cash Transfer Programmes in India: Evidence from Maharashtra and Odisha, examined two major state schemes using account-level monthly panel data. These include Maharashtra's Mukhyamantri Majhi Ladki Bahin Yojana, which provides eligible women Rs 1,500 every month, and Odisha's Subhadra Yojana, under which beneficiaries receive Rs 10,000 annually in two instalments.

According to the study, both programmes produced "large, statistically significant,

Continued on P4

Amit Shah hails BJP govt's 'Sonar Bangla' push

BENGAL TO PROPOSE MOOKERJEE'S INCLUSION IN SCHOOL, VARSITY CURRICULUM: SUVENDU

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: On the occasion of the 125th birth anniversary of Syama Prasad Mookerjee, while Union Home Minister Amit Shah said the BJP government in West Bengal was delivering on the promises made in its election manifesto and asserted that the vision of a "Sonar Bangla" was steadily taking shape under Chief Minister Suvenndu Adhikari, the CM announced that the state would propose the inclusion of Mookerjee's life and contributions in school and university curricula from the next academic session.

Shah also highlighted the BJP's commitment to tackling illegal immigration, saying every infiltrator would be identified and the country's security strengthened.

"We are fulfilling the promises we made in our 'Sankalp Patra' during the Bengal elections," Shah said.

Speaking at Mitra Institution, Mookerjee's alma mater, CM Adhikari said the proposed syllabus would include Mookerjee's role in the creation of West Bengal, his vision of national unity, his contribution as Independent India's first Industry minister and as vice-chancellor of the University of Calcutta.

He also said references



Amit Shah and Suvenndu Adhikari during the programme, in Kolkata, on Monday

to the Singur movement introduced during the previous government would be removed from school textbooks, subject to the syllabus committee's approval.

Shah, after reaching the city on Monday, laid the foundation stone for a 125-foot statue of Mookerjee at Eco Park in New Town in the presence of Adhikari. Calling the ceremony the beginning of a larger vision, Shah said: "I see this bhoomi puja differently. Today marks the beginning of fulfilling the resolve to build a Sonar Bangla."

Shah later visited Mookerjee's ancestral residence in Bhawanipore before making an unannounced

Continued on P4



RAIDS ACROSS DELHI, PUNJAB, UP

# SPECIAL CELL OP: Terror plot foiled, six held



NARESH BISWANI

**NEW DELHI:** Delhi Police special cell has arrested six terrorists in connection with two terror modules and an arms racket, allegedly linked to Pakistan-based gangster and terrorist Shahzad Bhatti. The accused were arrested from Delhi, Punjab and Uttar Pradesh during simultaneous raids in various locations, the officials informed on Monday.

In the operation, Delhi Police busted an alleged terror module and an illegal arms supply chain, with both networks allegedly operating in tandem and having links with Bhatti.

Officials said that the arrested individuals are being questioned to understand the inner working of the terror network, identify other members and probe the larger conspiracy, if any. Police added that more arrests are likely in the

**More arrests are likely in the near future as the investigation unfolds: Cops**

near future as the investigation unfolds.

During the raids, cops recovered firearms, petrol bombs and vehicles allegedly used by the terror modules. The recovered arms and explosives have been sent for forensic testing while police are examining digital evidence and other material found during the searches. Authorities said the financial trail, logistics and communications of the modules are also being probed to understand their working pattern.

Police are also looking into whether the arrested suspects have been involved in planning or supporting terror attacks,

apart from examining their alleged role in the recent attack on RSS office in Ranchi.

“The petrol bombs used in the Ranchi attack and the ones recovered from the arrested accused have been sent for forensic analysis. However, as of now, no direct link has been found between the terror module and the RSS attack. Similarly, both terror modules have been uncovered as part of our efforts to target Pakistan’s terror networks operating in India,” Delhi Police special cell said in a statement.

Police added that the investigation into Delhi terror module is at a nascent stage and more evidence is expected to come out as the trial proceeds.

Authorities said they are looking into the role played by each accused and said more discoveries during searches could lead to additional arrests in days to come.

# Cops arrest husband in dowry death case

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

**NEW DELHI:** The Delhi Police have arrested the husband of a 28-year-old newlywed woman who died after allegedly falling from the third floor of the NDMC residential flats at Palika Kunj in South Delhi’s Lodhi Colony, after registering a case of dowry death in connection with the incident.

According to the police, a case under the relevant provisions related to dowry death was registered at Lodhi Colony Police Station on July 5 following the completion of legal formalities. The deceased’s husband, Arastu Sikka, has since been arrested, and further investigation into the case is underway. The woman, identified as Akriti, a resident of Pushp Vihar, was found critically injured outside the NDMC residential complex on the evening of July 4.

She was rushed to the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS), where doctors declared her brought dead.

Initially, police initiated inquest proceedings under Section 196 of the Bharatiya

Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), informing the Sub-Divisional Magistrate while examining all possible angles surrounding the death. Investigators said the deceased had married Arastu Sikka on April 24 this year. She worked as a sales executive in Chhatarpur.

Police are examining CCTV footage and questioning residents of the area to reconstruct her movements before the incident, as it remains unclear why she was present at the NDMC housing complex, located several kilometres away from her marital home in Pushp Vihar.

The woman’s family has alleged that she was subjected to repeated physical and mental harassment over dowry demands after what they described as a love marriage.

According to her relatives, her husband and in-laws allegedly demanded a car and cash, while also pressuring her to hand over her entire salary.

Family members claimed she wished to continue financially supporting her widowed mother, leading to frequent disputes with her husband.

Her relatives further alleged that the couple had a major argument shortly before her death and insisted that she was mentally strong and unlikely to have died by suicide.

They have demanded strict action against her husband and in-laws, alleging that she was either murdered or driven to death through sustained harassment.

Police said the exact cause and circumstances of Akriti’s death will be established through the ongoing investigation and forensic evidence.

Delhi Police nab murder accused after 29 YEARS

**OUR CORRESPONDENT**

**NEW DELHI:** A man accused of murdering a co-worker in west Delhi in 1997 and remaining on the run for nearly 29 years has been arrested by the crime branch of the Delhi Police, an official said on Monday.

The accused, identified as Mohammad Fahim alias Ali Bhai, was wanted in connection with the murder of 58-year-old Sharif Hasan Khan and was declared a proclaimed offender by a court later in 1997 after evading arrest despite repeated efforts by police.

“Fahim was arrested from Thakurganj in Lucknow on July 3 following months of fresh investigation, intelligence gathering and technical surveillance that helped crack one of Delhi Police’s oldest pending murder cases,” a senior police officer said.

The case dates back to March 14, 1997, when the body of an unidentified man was recovered from a room at TC Camp in Raghunagar. During the investigation, the deceased was identified as Sharif Hasan Khan, a resident of Faizabad district, now Ayodhya, in Uttar Pradesh, who worked at a clothing shop in Rajouri Garden.

“Fahim had come to Delhi in search of work and had become acquainted with Khan. On March 13, 1997, the two allegedly got into a dispute after Fahim stole money from the victim. During the altercation, he assaulted Khan repeatedly with an iron rod and later strangled him with a rope to ensure his death before hiding the body inside a wooden bed box and fleeing the city,” the officer said.

The crime branch said the case was recently assigned to its central range for reinvestigation. Officers re-examined the nearly three-decade-old case despite the absence of recent photographs, reliable identification records and modern digital evidence, as the crime predated contemporary investigative databases.

Police said the team developed local intelligence in the accused’s native village, which indicated that he was alive and occasionally visited the area. Continuous surveillance later traced his movements to Lucknow, where a police team conducted a planned operation and apprehended him.

During interrogation, Fahim confessed to killing Khan over the monetary dispute.

# Monsoon mission gets tough

OUR CORRESPONDENT

**NEW DELHI:** Adopting a “zero-tolerance” approach towards waterlogging, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday directed officials to ensure time-bound action on monsoon-related issues while reviewing the progress of Mission Kayakalp, preparations for the Kanwar Yatra and infrastructure improvements in government schools.

Chairing a meeting of the District Development Committee (DDC) Apex Committee at the Delhi Secretariat, the Chief Minister reviewed works being carried out in two of the most dilapidated government schools identified in each district under Mission Kayakalp. The meeting was attended by MLAs, all 13 District Magistrates and senior officials. Reviewing school infrastructure, Gupta said the objective was not only to improve education but also to provide children with a clean, safe and inspiring learning environment. She appreciated district administrations that had developed libraries, STEM and science laboratories, computer labs, smart classrooms, renovated toilets, water coolers and wall paintings, while specially commend-



ing the District Magistrates of Outer North, North-East and New Delhi for their work.

She directed all District Magistrates to prioritise basic facilities such as toilets, drinking water, furniture, laboratories and libraries, making it clear that poorly maintained school toilets would not be tolerated.

The Chief Minister also reviewed monsoon preparedness and took stock of waterlogging-prone areas across the city, including Baljeet Nagar, Patel Nagar, Sangam Vihar, Bawana, Kirari, Patparganj, Laxmi Nagar, Krishna Nagar and Mandawali.

Reiterating her government’s stance, Gupta said, “Waterlogging will not be accepted under

any circumstances in the Capital. DDC Chairpersons and officials must personally monitor the situation on the ground.” She directed officials to conduct field inspections instead of relying on reports, ensure timely desilting of drains, deploy pumps at vulnerable locations and improve coordination among agencies to resolve pending issues.

The meeting also reviewed preparations for the upcoming Kanwar Yatra. District Magistrates were instructed to coordinate with organisers and ensure adequate arrangements for drinking water, sanitation, medical facilities, electricity and traffic management for devotees.

# Delhi University to hold webinars on UG admissions process

ANAMTA FATIMA

**NEW DELHI:** The University of Delhi’s Admission Branch will conduct two live webinars this week to guide undergraduate aspirants through the admission process for the 2026-27 academic session under the Common Seat Allocation System (CSAS).

The first webinar, scheduled for July 8 at 3 p.m., will focus on the UG-Common Seat Allocation System (CSAS) 2026, including the admission process, preference filling, seat allocation and key university policies. The second session, to be held on July 9 at 3 p.m., will explain the admission process under the Extra-Curricular Activities (ECA) and Sports Quota.

The sessions will be addressed by Prof. Hanee Gandhi, Dean (Admissions), and Prof. Anand Sonkar, Joint Dean (Admissions). Students

will also have the opportunity to post their queries during the live chat, with officials responding to frequently asked questions and clarifying admission-related concerns.

According to the University, the webinars aim to familiarise candidates with the online admission procedure and help them make informed choices while filling programme and college preferences under the CSAS portal. Officials are also expected to explain important admission guidelines and policies to ensure a smooth admission process.

The webinars will be streamed live on the University of Delhi’s official YouTube channel. The University has encouraged undergraduate aspirants and their parents to participate in the sessions to better understand the admission process and resolve their doubts before the commencement of seat allocation.

# Fake govt ID racket busted

OUR CORRESPONDENT

**NEW DELHI:** An inter-state racket allegedly involved in preparing and selling forged government identity documents through a website has been unearthed with the arrest of two persons, an official said on Monday.

According to the Delhi Police’s Intelligence Fusion and Strategic Operations (IFSO) unit, the accused have been identified as Bideshi Saw, a resident of Daman and Diu, and Santosh Kumar, a resident of Patna in Bihar.

“The duo operated the website bkprint.in, which enabled users to generate forged Aadhaar cards, voter identity cards, PAN-related documents, residence certificates, caste certificates, birth and death certificates and other government document-like records after making online payments,” Deputy Commissioner of

Police (IFSO) Vinit Kumar said in a statement.

The forged documents closely resembled genuine government-issued documents and were capable of being misused for identity theft, impersonation, cheating, financial fraud and even for obtaining genuine government documents on the basis of forged records. “The case came to light during social media monitoring and cyber patrolling when information was received that forged government documents were being prepared and supplied online through the website,” the DCP said.

During verification, a team found that the portal was openly offering services for generating Aadhaar cards, voter identity cards, PAN-related documents, residence certificates, caste certificates, birth and death certificates and several other document-like records.

MCD TRIBUTE



MCD marks Dr. Shyama Prasad Mukherjee's 125th birth anniversary with floral tributes at the Civic Centre

MP0ST

# CAQM flags 62 pollution violations

**NEW DELHI:** Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM) inspections at construction and demolition (C&D) sites and industrial units across the national Capital region between June 14 and June 30 have flagged 62 violations of pollution control norms, officials said on Monday. The CAQM Enforcement Task Force (ETF), at its 134th meeting on Monday, reviewed reports from 173 inspections and enforcement actions carried out across NCR during the period.

Flying squads carried out 15 inspections across C&D sites, 91 inspections in industrial clusters and 67 inspections related to diesel generator sets.

A total of 62 violations were reported, including seven from C&D sites, 31 from industrial units and 24 in diesel generator sets.

“The ETF also reviewed actions taken pursuant to the 133rd meeting and noted that all actionable cases pertaining to industrial sector, construction and demolition sector, and diesel generator sets have been acted upon by the concerned agencies,” an official said. MP0ST

# Love triangle ends in murder

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

**NEW DELHI:** A 20-year-old married woman was allegedly shot dead by her husband with the help of his girlfriend in Haryana’s Gurugram, weeks after the high-profile Ketan Agarwal murder case drew attention to another alleged crime involving intimate relationships.

According to the police, the accused, identified as Ankit (25) and his alleged girlfriend Rajni (38) have been arrested after remaining on the run for over a month. Police said the duo allegedly concealed the victim’s body inside a bathroom before fleeing the area.

According to investigators, the incident took place on May 21 when Ankit allegedly took his wife, Madhu, to Rajni’s house in Manesar. Police alleged that the murder was premeditated and that the accused had procured the firearm nearly two months in advance with the intention of carrying out the killing. After allegedly shooting Madhu, the two hid her body in the bathroom and escaped.

The crime came to light after Madhu’s mother

approached the police on May 22 and lodged a missing person’s complaint.

An FIR was initially registered under the relevant provisions for a missing person. As the investigation progressed and evidence emerged indicating foul play, police added murder charges and intensified the probe. During the investigation, officers found that Ankit and Rajni had allegedly been in a relationship for the past three years.

Police said Ankit operated a tobacco shop in Manesar, while Rajni worked at a beauty parlour in the same locality.

Investigators further revealed that the accused fled to Haridwar soon after the murder and later crossed into Nepal to evade arrest.

They allegedly remained absconding until June 30, when they returned to India. Acting on specific inputs, the Crime Branch team in Manesar apprehended both accused.

They were produced before a local court, which remanded them to five days of police custody for further interrogation. Police are continuing their investigation to establish the complete sequence of events and gather additional evidence in the case.

3 HELD FOR REVENGE MURDER IN NORTH DELHI

# Tattoo helps identification of mutilated body

OUR CORRESPONDENT

**NEW DELHI:** Tattoos on a man whose face was mutilated beyond recognition helped Delhi Police establish his identity and crack a revenge murder case, leading to the arrest of three men who allegedly killed him, officials said on Monday.

The police said that the accused evaded arrest by moving across several states for more than six weeks.

“The victim was identified as Chandan Saini (34), a resident of Nehru Vihar in north Delhi, whose body bearing multiple stab wounds was found in the Yamuna Khadar area in

Wazirabad on May 21,” Deputy Commissioner of Police (North) Raja Banthia said in a statement.

The police said the victim’s face had been severely disfigured, making identification impossible. However, the teams noticed a tattoo carrying two names and a symbol on his hand. The image was circulated locally, enabling police to establish his identity. Further verification revealed that Saini was a bad character of Timarpur police station and had previous involvement in five cases of snatching, burglary and theft.

An FIR of murder was registered at Wazirabad police station, following which joint

teams were formed to investigate the case and to arrest the accused in the murder.

Teams scanned CCTV footage from the victim’s neighbourhood and the route leading to the crime scene.

CCTV footage from the neighbourhood showed Saini boarding an autorickshaw outside his house on the intervening night of May 20 and 21.

The team could not ascertain the registration number of the vehicle; they established that he had willingly left with its occupants,” the officer said.

The breakthrough came during the questioning of Surjeet alias Bacchi, an associate of the

deceased and also a bad character of Timarpur police station.

He told investigators that Saini had an old enmity with Tarun alias Tanni and frequently abused him and his friends.

He also disclosed that on May 18, just two days before the murder, Saini and his associates had allegedly assaulted and attempted to abduct Tarun’s brother, Saurabh, during a quarrel. Based on the disclosures, Tarun emerged as the prime suspect. However, when police raided his residence, he had already fled.

“The teams subsequently found that Tarun’s cousin Sunny Mahajan from Amritsar and his

friend Dheeraj had also disappeared after the incident,” he added. The trio kept changing locations, moving through Mumbai, Amritsar, Katra in Jammu, Haridwar, Loni in Ghaziabad and other places to avoid arrest. The accused frequently stayed at gurdwaras while on the run and returned to Delhi only around 10 days before their arrest, taking shelter near Gurdwara Sis Ganj Sahib in Chandni Chowk.

“On July 5, acting on a tip-off, police apprehended Dheeraj from Loni in Ghaziabad. Based on his interrogation, Tarun and Sunny were arrested later the same day from a mortuary in

north Delhi,” he said.

During questioning, Tarun confessed that he planned the murder to avenge the attack on his brother.

According to the police, he roped in Sunny and Dheeraj, hired an autorickshaw and picked up Saini from his residence on the pretext of consuming liquor.

The accused allegedly assaulted Saini inside the autorickshaw before taking him to a forested stretch near Yamuna Khadar, where they repeatedly stabbed him to death. They later fled Delhi and kept moving between different states to evade arrest, the police said.



Delhi govt to launch 300 new e-buses today

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government will roll out around 300 new electric buses on Tuesday, strengthening its bus fleet across the city.

According to officials, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta will launch the buses in the RK Puram area of South Delhi, along with laying the foundation stone for a new bus depot.

Currently, Delhi has around 4,500 electric buses and a total of around 7,000 buses, making the national capital a city with one of the biggest EV bus fleets in the country.

The Rekha Gupta government on June 30 notified the Delhi Electric Vehicles Policy 2026, which aims to accelerate EV adoption, improve air quality and create a supportive ecosystem for electric mobility.

One aspect of the policy is that the government will make efforts to induct only electric buses.

“All new intra-state buses to be inducted by the Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) and the Transport Department from the date of notification of this policy, shall be electric,” the policy states.

In the past one year, the Delhi Transport Corporation has been increasing the numbers of its small 9-metre buses, which are expected to improve connectivity on certain routes. The new steps to increase the number of buses are jointly funded under the PM E-Drive initiative of the Centre.

# Safety bell rings across 5,633 schools

## Child protection panels to be set up in every school; staff to under POCSO training

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a major push to strengthen protection mechanisms for children, the Delhi government has directed that Child Protection Committees be established in all 5,633 schools across the Capital by the end of July, while ordering a citywide expansion of POCSO awareness programmes, mandatory safety protocols and joint school inspections.

The decision was taken at a high-level review meeting on Monday chaired by Lieutenant Governor Sardar Taranjit Singh Sandhu and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta at Raj Niwas to assess the progress of initiatives being undertaken as part of the ongoing Child Protection Month.

The meeting, attended by senior officials including the Chief Secretary, Commissioner of Police, Secretaries of the Education and Women and Child Development Departments and senior Delhi Police officers, reviewed measures being implemented by various departments to improve child safety across schools and institutions.

The Education Department informed the meeting that a comprehensive student safety checklist, based on guidelines of the National Commission for Protection of Child Rights (NCPCR), the Delhi Commission for Protection of Child Rights (DCPCR) and the POCSO Act, is being implemented across all 5,633 schools,



including government, aided, MCD, NDMC, Delhi Cantonment Board and private schools.

Teachers, school staff and master trainers are being trained under the POCSO Act, while students are receiving awareness sessions on safe and unsafe touch, gender sensitisation and personal boundaries. Self-defence training and special safety measures for children with special needs are also being introduced.

Delhi Police informed the

meeting that dedicated initiatives are underway for the safety of schoolchildren, missing children, children in parks, JJ clusters, orphanages and Child Care Institutions. Each district has designated an Additional Deputy Commissioner of Police as the nodal officer to monitor POCSO-related cases and coordinate action.

The Women and Child Development Department presented its plan to expand POCSO awareness campaigns to

Anganwadi-cum-Palna Centres, linked centres and all Child Care Institutions using mobile awareness vans, videos and printed material.

Reviewing the progress, the Lieutenant Governor said, “There is no room for complacency in ensuring a safe and sensitive environment for every child.” He directed that child protection initiatives should become a permanent feature of all institutions rather than remain limited to July.

### SAFE SCHOOLS

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CM slams Kejriwal over his criticism of BJP president

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: AAP supremo Arvind Kejriwal’s “who are you” remarks targeting BJP president Nitin Nabin have triggered a fresh political slugfest between the two parties, with Chief Minister Rekha Gupta saying her predecessor’s “ego was still riding high”. Kejriwal had taken a swipe at the BJP president after he targeted opposition leaders, including the former Delhi chief minister, for remaining silent over “insult” of Hindu deities.

Throwing her weight behind Nabin, Gupta noted that he had represented Bihar’s Bankipur Assembly constituency for four consecutive terms, risen through the ranks from a Yuva Morcha worker and was now a Rajya Sabha member. Claiming that Kejriwal was “desperate and disheartened”, Gupta alleged in a post on X on Sunday night that, “His ego was still riding high in the seventh heaven”.

Noting that then West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee had once asked, “Who is Amit Shah?”, she said, “Time answers every question and even Ravana’s arrogance could not survive.” AAP leader and Leader of Opposition in the Delhi Assembly Atishi said BJP leaders, who had objected to the alleged insult of Nabin, were silent over what she described as an “insult” to Lord Bajrang Bali. Referring to a video from Nabin’s rally in which a child dressed as Lord Hanuman was seen dancing, she questioned whether BJP leaders had the courage to speak against it as well.

## Barapullah Phase 3 deadline missed

### Likely to be completed this month

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: With the construction work still not completed, the Barapullah Phase 3 project has once again missed its last deadline as officials on Monday said work is likely to be over this month.

Public Works Department (PWD) Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh had given the deadline of June 30 for completion of Barapullah Phase 3, but even one week later, the work is not completed. “The main construction work has been completed, however, some finishing touches are ongoing, which is likely to be completed this month,” a government official said.

Last month, on June 22, Singh even visited the construction site to witness the casting of the last slab of the flyover. The project, which was approved in 2014 and initiated in 2015, was originally targeted for com-

pletion in 2017. The work saw repeated delays and significant cost escalation, with the revised project cost now standing at approximately Rs 1,635 crore.

The project envisages seamless connectivity between East and South Delhi, connecting Mayur Vihar Phase 1 and AIIMS, on signal-free carriageways. The new flyover will merge with the existing Barapullah flyover at Sarai Kale Khan, completing a stretch of around 9 km.

According to officials, both the ramps of the elevated corridor, one from the Mayur Vihar side and the other continuing from the existing corridor near Sarai Kale Khan, have been completed. The PWD has also completed the work of an extradosed bridge, featuring shorter towers and shallower cable angles, over the Yamuna connecting Sarai Kale Khan and Mayur Vihar.

NDMC to plant 600 trees at 34 locations in mega plantation drive

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) will launch a mega tree plantation drive at 34 locations across its jurisdiction on Tuesday, with a target of planting around 600 trees and 50,000 shrubs under the Centre’s ‘Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam’ campaign, officials said on Monday. NDMC Vice Chairperson Kuljeet Singh Chahal said the plantation drive will coincide with the Delhi government’s campaign to plant 70 lakh trees across the national capital. According to NDMC, more than 50,000 planting pits have already been prepared for the drive. “The civic body plans to plant native tree species such as peepal, neem, jamun, imli, champa, ashoka, gulmohar and amaltas, along with ornamental and indigenous shrubs including hamelia, justicia, canna, lily and murraya to improve biodiversity and green cover,” Chahal said in a statement. Chahal said NDMC council members, heads of departments, officers and employees will take part in the plantation drive at different locations across the council area.

He said the civic body views plantation as an ongoing exercise rather than a one-day event. Under its “Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam – On Sunday” campaign, NDMC has conducted 31 consecutive weekly plantation drives, while similar activities are also organised during national festivals and other public events. The campaign has also seen participation from resident welfare associations, market traders’ associations, schools, institutions and residents, Chahal said.

## MCD fixes July 15 for key panel polls

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi on Monday announced elections for six vacant seats in its Standing Committee and for chairpersons and deputy chairpersons of its 12 ward committees on July 15, more than a month after the polls were cancelled indefinitely.

The Municipal Secretary issued separate notices notifying the election schedule, stating that the last date to file nomination papers is July 10.

The elections were earlier scheduled for June 3 but were postponed “until further orders” on May 27. The MCD had not cited any reason for the decision. At the time, Leader of the Opposition Ankush Narang of AAP had alleged that the BJP had deferred the polls due to internal differences.

The Standing Committee currently has 12 members against its sanctioned strength of 18 after nine members retired on March 31 following the completion of the delayed draw of lots process. Of the retired members, six belonged to the BJP and three to the Aam Aadmi

Party (AAP). Subsequently, three vacancies were filled by the House on April 29, while six seats remained vacant. Jai Bhagwan Yadav from Begumpur and Manish Chadha from Paharganj were elected to the committee from the BJP, while Jajal Chaudhary from Shalimar Bagh was elected from the AAP.

The elections to the Standing Committee will be held in Keshav Puram, Narela, Central, Najafgarh, Shahdara South, and Karol Bagh ward committees, electing one member each.

The vacancies arose following the rotation-based retirement of Shikha Bhardwaj, Anju Devi, Inderjeet Sehrawat, Rajpal Singh, Neema Bhagat and Ankush Narang under the provisions of the Delhi Municipal Corporation Act. Apart from electing Standing Committee members in the six concerned ward committees, all 12 ward committees will elect their chairpersons and deputy chairpersons. The standing committee is the highest decision-making body of the MCD and is responsible for granting approval unanimously to proposals.

## Warmest July day since 2024

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Unusually high humidity made for an uncomfortable Monday in Delhi, pushing the “feel-like” temperature to 49.6 degrees Celsius in parts of the city.

According to the Meteorological department, Delhi continued to reel under sweltering weather conditions, with the maximum temperature settling above normal at most weather stations, even as no rainfall was recorded in the city during the day. According to the India Meteorological Department (IMD), the national capital’s base station at Safdarjung recorded a maximum temperature of 38.6 degrees Celsius, two notches above the seasonal average. The minimum temperature was 27 degrees Celsius, 0.9 degrees below normal.

Similar to Sunday, Monday marked the warmest July day in two years, with the maximum temperature at 38.6 degrees Celsius. The last time the temperature was higher was on July 11, 2024, when it reached 38.8 degrees Celsius.

Palam registered a maximum temperature of 38.5 degrees Celsius, 1.1 degrees above normal, while the minimum settled at 26 degrees



Celsius, 2.2 notches below the average. Lodhi Road recorded a high of 38.3 degrees Celsius, 3.3 degrees above normal – the highest positive departure among the city’s major weather stations. Its minimum temperature stood at 27.8 degrees Celsius, 0.8 degrees above normal.

The Ridge station recorded a maximum temperature of 38.1 degrees Celsius, 1.9 notches above normal, while the minimum was 24 degrees Celsius, 2.4 degrees below normal.

At Ay Nagar, the maximum temperature settled at 37.7 degrees Celsius, 1.1 degrees above normal, and the minimum was recorded at 27.4 degrees Celsius, 0.7 degrees above normal.

The IMD said no rainfall was recorded at any of the five major observatories between 8.30 am

and 5.30 pm on Monday. Safdarjung received 6.4 mm of rainfall during the 24-hour period ending at 8.30 am, followed by 16.4 mm at Palam, 11.1 mm at Ridge, 8.2 mm at Ay Nagar and 1.6 mm at Lodhi Road. However, the city remained dry through the day after the morning observations.

The maximum and minimum temperatures for Tuesday are expected to settle at 36 and 27 degrees Celsius, respectively, with IMD issuing a ‘yellow alert’ predicting moderate rain and generally cloudy skies in parts of the city.

The capital’s Air Quality Index (AQI) was recorded in the ‘satisfactory’ category on Saturday, and the 24-hour average AQI stood at 94 at 4 pm, according to Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) data.

## City Briefs

### CONSTRUCTION WORK TO AFFECT WATER SUPPLY IN PARTS OF SOUTH DELHI: DJB

NEW DELHI: Water supply is likely to be affected in several parts of South Delhi on Monday and Tuesday amid construction work by the Delhi Jal Board, officials said.

According to the DJB officials, in compliance with a Delhi High Court order for constructing the boundary wall of the Taimoor Nagar Drain, the newly laid 1,500 mm water line is being interconnected with the existing water line. “Due to major maintenance work on the 1,900 mm South Delhi Main pipeline at Sonia Vihar water treatment plant (WTP), water supply may remain unavailable or at low pressure in several places in South Delhi from July 6-7 till 4 pm,” the DJB said in an alert. Residents are requested to store adequate water in advance. Water tankers can be availed by calling the respective Water Emergency numbers, it added. Areas including Deer Park, East of Kailash, Hauz Rani, Sheikh Sarai, Swami Nagar, CR Park, Greater Kailash 2 and 3, Malviya Nagar and adjoining areas are likely to be affected.

### DELHI AAP PROTEST OUTSIDE LNJP HOSP ALLEGING RS 650 CRORE HEALTH SCAM

NEW DELHI: The Aam Aadmi Party on Monday staged a protest at LNJP Hospital over an alleged Rs 650 crore scam in the Delhi government, questioning Chief Minister Rekha Gupta why the main accused was allowed to flee to Germany. “There was a health scam worth Rs 650 crore in Delhi. The main accused was not arrested by the ACB for a month, and he was allowed to flee to Germany. We kept saying it and kept holding press conferences, demanding the arrest of Rajiv Rangeela. They did not arrest him. Why not? Because they do not want to investigate,” AAP Delhi President Saurabh Bharadwaj told PTI videos.

### SAFETY ADVISORY ISSUED TO PREVENT RAIN-RELATED ACCIDENTS

## RAIN-READY: Discoms issue advisory

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Power discoms in the city on Monday issued an advisory urging people to avoid electricity-related accidents even as they have begun undertaking measures under the Monsoon action plan to minimise moisture-related breakdowns and rain-related disruptions.

A BSES spokesperson said that during the monsoon, waterlogging increases the chances of electricity-related mishaps. Simple precautions like stay-

ing away from electrical installations, such as electricity poles, substations, transformers and streetlights, and preventing children from playing near electrical installations, can prevent accidents. As part of a special ‘Current Leakage Testing Drive’, Tata Power Delhi Distribution Limited (TPDDL) undertook testing of electric poles, ATMs, streetlights, substation fencing, grill fencing of parks, and gates and other installations in schools, hospitals and other public premises, said a company statement.

A special Public Installa-



eties of mangoes from across the country, giving visitors an opportunity to explore rare and popular cultivars. Besides fresh mangoes, stalls also offered mango saplings and a wide

range of value-added products, including pickles, jams, jellies, mango panna and mango papad, attracting enthusiastic buyers.

One of the biggest crowd-pullers was the Mango Eating

Competition, where participants had to consume up to three kilograms of mango pulp within three minutes. The event witnessed enthusiastic participation from both men and women. In the women’s category, 20 contestants took part in the competition. Kavita Chaudhary emerged as the winner after consuming 1,310 kg of mango pulp within the stipulated time. Beena secured the second position by eating 1,300

kg, while the third prize went to a participant who consumed 1,139 kg of mango pulp. The winners were felicitated during the closing ceremony. According to Delhi Tourism, the festival aims to provide a common platform for mango growers from across the country to showcase their produce while promoting scientific cultivation practices and encouraging new orchard owners to adopt modern farming techniques.

consumers should also get electrical wiring at their premises checked by a licensed contractor, and switch off the main supply in case of waterlogging or leakage in the meter cabin. Installing an earth leakage circuit breaker helps prevent shocks and mishaps; wet switches need to be avoided, and instead a tester could be used to detect if current is leaking, the official said. Power theft through hooking can be a serious safety hazard, especially during the monsoon and should be avoided, the spokesperson

said and added that the BSES discoms have to, at times, switch off power supply in vulnerable or waterlogged areas in the interest of public safety.

Talking about the Monsoon action plan, the spokesperson said BSES discoms follow an integrated and proactive approach, and measures are being undertaken to minimise moisture-related breakdowns and rain-related disruptions.

In case of an emergency or power disruption, consumers can reach BSES through call centres, WhatsApp and mobile

apps. War rooms have been set up and quick response teams deployed to respond swiftly to monsoon-related exigencies.

BSES has also launched a campaign to sensitise consumers on monsoon safety precautions, the official said.

The discoms have also taken steps like raising the foundation height of transformers in low-lying areas, preventing waterlogging, seepage and moisture in switchgear, ensuring proper fencing around plinth and pole-mounted transformers, to prevent supply disruptions.



JAISHANKAR ON A FOUR-NATION VISIT TO GULF

# EAM Jaishankar meets Bahrain FM, discusses bilateral cooperation

**MANAMA:** External Affairs minister S Jaishankar met Bahrain's Foreign Minister Abdullahi bin Rashid Al Zayani on Monday and discussed deepening bilateral cooperation and ongoing developments in the region.

Jaishankar arrived in Bahrain from Qatar on the second leg of this four-nation visit to the Gulf, which also includes Kuwait and Oman, from July 5 to 10. "Delighted to meet FM Dr. Abdullahi bin Rashid Al Zayani of Bahrain in Manama today. Discussed deepening our bilateral cooperation. Exchanged views on ongoing developments in the region," Jaishankar said in a post on X.



EAM S Jaishankar during a meeting with Bahrain's Foreign Minister Abdullahi bin Rashid Al Zayani, in Manama, Bahrain

Jaishankar expressed deep appreciation for Bahrain's role in ensuring the well-being of the Indian community in the country. During the ongoing visit, Jaishankar will meet his counterparts and top leaders of the four Gulf countries to enhance bilateral relations and exchange views on regional developments and issues of mutual interest.

The Gulf visit comes against the backdrop of fast-evolving political dynamics in West Asia following the signing of an agreement aimed at ending the US-Iran conflict.

Bahrain was under direct Iranian missile and drone strikes before the ceasefire.

Qatar and Oman have emerged as mediators, along with Pakistan, in bringing about the Iran ceasefire following weeks of escalating tensions. The indirect talks between the US and Iran in Doha are set to continue after the week-long funeral rites of Iran's slain supreme leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, which started on Friday.

During his Qatar visit on Sunday, Jaishankar met Prime Minister Mohammed bin Abdulrahman Al-Thani and reviewed cooperation in energy, trade, investments, connectivity and security.

After visiting the four Gulf countries, Jaishankar will travel to New York on July 13 to launch India's official campaign for the UN Security Council tenure 2028-29. He will then attend the 3rd India-EU Trade and Technology Council meeting in Brussels on July 14-15.

## Hamas dissolves govt in Gaza, plans...

**Continued from Page 1**

General director of the Hamas-run Government Media Office, said "only technical and professional staff" would remain in their positions to run the Palestinian enclave's day-to-day affairs. "All employees working in service provision are state employees" and are fully prepared to work under the National Committee for the Administration of Gaza," al-Thawabta said during a news conference in the courtyard of Al-Aqsa Hospital in Deir al-Balah.

Hamas spokesperson Hazem Qassem called it "a positive step forward on the path to implement the ceasefire deal."

Israel dismissed the announcement as irrelevant. "The alleged resignation of the Hamas government, where all of the Hamas members stay in their positions, is a spin that has no significance," an Israeli official said, speaking on condition of anonymity because they were not authorised to speak to the media.

The committee of technocrats, which is based in Cairo, is chaired

by Ali Shaath, a Gaza-born engineer and former official with the Palestinian Authority. It has a mandate to restore essential services and oversee civilian affairs under the supervision of the UN and Board of Peace. In a statement on X, Shaath acknowledged the Hamas announcement Monday and said that in order for the committee to function effectively, there must be "a single governing authority operating under one legal framework" and "a unified security apparatus accountable to that authority."

Nine months after the ceasefire was signed, negotiations between Israel and Hamas remain largely deadlocked over the implementation of its second phase, including the disarmament of Hamas and the reconstruction of Gaza. Hamas has insisted on implementing the first phase before moving to discuss its weapons. The October 7, 2023, attack by Hamas-led militants that sparked the war killed some 1,200 people in Israel and saw 251 others taken hostage. Israel's retaliatory offensive in Gaza has killed 73,098

Palestinians, according to Gaza's Health Ministry. The ministry, part of the Hamas-led government, is staffed by medical professionals and maintains detailed records viewed as generally reliable by UN agencies and independent experts. It does not distinguish between civilians and militants but says women and children make up around half of all fatalities. Israeli strikes have lessened considerably since the ceasefire took effect on October 10, but they continue almost daily. Israel's military says it targets Hamas and other militants, often asserting they were planning attacks. On Monday, Israeli strikes killed at least five people in Gaza, including three in Khan Younis in the south and two in an apartment in Gaza City, health officials said. The Israeli military said it targeted a Hamas operative in the Gaza City strike and a militant from the Palestinian Islamic Jihad in the attacks in Khan Younis. Militants have carried out shooting attacks against Israeli troops in Gaza, and five Israeli soldiers have been killed since the ceasefire.

## From Page 1

### Trust accepts resignations

Rai and Mishra did not attend the meeting.

Trust treasurer Swami Govind Dev Giri said Rai and Mishra had submitted their resignations after allegations surfaced over the theft of crores of rupees in cash donations and other offerings made by devotees. He said the Trust accepted the resignations because, under its constitution, they became effective once submitted. Senior trustee K Parasaran had advised that the Trust had no discretion to reject them.

Giri said Rai voluntarily stepped down because he believed it was not appropriate to continue in office until the investigation was completed and those responsible were brought to justice. At the same time, the Trust unanimously acknowledged Rai's contribution to the Ram Temple movement and construction. Defending him, Giri said Rai was "untainted in my eyes" and suggested his only mistake may have been trusting the wrong people.

Krishna Mohan, who will serve as interim general secretary until a permanent appointment is made, said his immediate priority would be to remove loopholes in the temple's management system, strengthen administrative processes and restore the confidence of devotees. He said the controversy had exposed weaknesses in the existing arrangements and assured that anyone found guilty would face appropriate punishment.

The Trust also announced the formation of a three-member search committee to identify a CEO for the temple trust. The panel comprises retired judge Pramod Kohli, retired Lieutenant General Vishnukant Chaturvedi and trustee Suresh Haware. Giri said the CEO would help strengthen transparency and administration, while Krishna Mohan would be free to choose a team to assist him during the transition.

The donation theft case is being investigated by a three-member SIT constituted by the Uttar Pradesh government on June 13 after the Trust itself sought a high-level probe. According to investigators, employees involved in counting temple offerings allegedly stole cash on nearly 70 occasions over a period of 40 days. Investigators have also claimed the accused knew about CCTV blind spots and at times switched off or blocked cameras while removing currency notes.

Police have arrested eight people so far, most of them involved in handling and counting donations. Those arrested include Rai's driver, Ramashankar Yadav alias Tinnu. None of the trustees has been named in the FIR. The Trust said the SIT's preliminary findings identified prima facie evidence against the eight accused, leading to the registration of cases and their arrests.

The Trust's next meeting has been scheduled for July 22, when it expects to receive the SIT's final report. Giri said the report would be discussed along with appointments of additional trustees. The Trust also said it would implement the SIT's recommendations and seek independent expert advice to build a stronger, more transparent and efficient administrative framework.

Responding to allegations that donated valuables had disappeared, the Trust said all 2,926 non-cash offerings received from devotees are safe and fully documented. It said every donated article has been entered in registers with date-wise records and undergoes annual physical verification by an independent chartered accountant firm serving as internal auditor. Silver offerings donated by devotees were converted into bullion at the Government of India's Mint, with photographs, purity certificates and weight records preserved. Giri displayed ornaments and other valuables before reporters and invited anyone with doubts to verify the records at the Trust office.

The controversy has also triggered political reactions. The Congress said the acceptance of the resignations amounted to an acknowledgment that the alleged donation theft had occurred and demanded a Supreme Court-supervised investigation. The Samajwadi Party also sought intervention by the apex court, while Uttar Pradesh Congress president Ajay Rai called for the dissolution of the Trust and its reconstitution under the guidance of the country's four Shankaracharyas and other seers.

## Monsoon

The India Meteorological Department (IMD) issued a red alert for Mumbai, Thane and Raigad, warning of more heavy to very heavy rainfall accompanied by strong winds. Authorities across several states stepped up emergency measures as roads, railways and airports struggled to cope with the continuing monsoon conditions.

In Maharashtra, heavy rain brought Mumbai and surrounding districts to a near standstill. Roads were submerged, trees were uprooted and several wall and billboard collapse incidents were reported. In Thane, a fireman was injured while removing a massive uprooted tree, while a large billboard and two walls collapsed in separate incidents.

The newly opened 13-kilometre Missing Link section of the Mumbai-Pune Expressway suffered a major setback during its first monsoon season after a concrete pillar fell onto the carriage-way. The expressway was shut between the Connecting Link and Missing Link sections, while stretches of the old Mumbai-Pune highway were also closed because of landslides, flooding and overflowing water.

The Missing Link project, built at a cost of Rs 7,181 crore, cuts through the Sahyadri mountains, reducing the travel distance between Mumbai and Pune by about six kilometres.

Heavy rain also severely affected railway operations. Landslides in the Bhor Ghat section forced suspension of train services on the busy Mumbai-Pune route, while ballast beneath tracks between Lowjee and Dolaivi stations was washed away, disrupting local train services between Karjat and Khopoli. Restoration work allowed partial resumption of operations by Monday evening.

Western Railway said more than 40 train services were affected because of waterlogging and landslides. At least 10 trains

were cancelled, eight rescheduled and several others diverted or short terminated. Heavy rainfall also led to the cancellation of four passenger trains operating between Bandra Terminus and Jaipur and Hisar.

Air travel was also disrupted. Five incoming flights to Mumbai were diverted because of poor weather. According to Mumbai International Airport, IndiGo flights from Raipur and Singapore were diverted to Hyderabad, an Akasa Air flight from Delhi was diverted to Ahmedabad, Air India's Kolkata flight was diverted to Bengaluru and an Oman Air flight from Muscat landed at Vadodara instead.

Railway Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw reviewed the situation and directed Central and Western Railway officials to speed up restoration work.

The heavy rain also affected governance. Both Houses of the Maharashtra Legislature were adjourned, while the Bombay High Court assured lawyers that no adverse orders would be passed if they were unable to reach court due to the weather.

Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis described the extreme rainfall as a "force majeure" situation beyond human control.

"The entire disaster management machinery, municipal corporations and other agencies are on the ground. We are in alert mode," he said, adding that with public cooperation such emergencies could be managed more effectively. He also said the recent incidents reflected extreme weather conditions rather than a lack of preparedness.

Fadnavis noted that around 800 trees usually fall during the monsoon, but 350 trees had fallen on Sunday alone.

Authorities advised private offices to allow employees to work from home and declared a half day for non-essential government and semi-government offices. Schools remained closed, reducing traffic on city roads.

In Pune district, two people died after their house was buried in a landslide at Patan village in Maval tehsil, where three landslides were reported. Another person died after being swept away while crossing a flooded road in Khed tehsil.

Maharashtra Disaster Management Minister Girish Mahajan said 13 people had died in rain-related incidents over the past three to four days and warned that the IMD's red alert would remain in effect for the next two days.

Nashik district was placed on high alert after forecasts warned of possible cloudburst-like rainfall in Trimbakeshwar, Igatpuri and nearby western areas on Tuesday. Schools, colleges, weekly markets and major temples, including Trimbakeshwar and Saptashringi, were ordered closed.

In neighbouring Palghar district, nearly 300 mm of rain fell within two hours in some areas. Strong winds blew away tin-roofed sheds and uprooted trees at a residential school, although all 350 students remained safe.

The weather crisis also sparked political exchanges. Opposition legislators protested outside the Maharashtra Legislature, accusing the government of failing to protect people during the monsoon and alleging that recent rainfall had exposed weak infrastructure across Mumbai and other parts of the state.

Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Ambadas Danve questioned how a concrete pillar of the recently opened Missing Link project had collapsed. Maharashtra Congress

president Harshwardhan Sapkal called the deaths an "administrative failure" and described the situation as a "man-made disaster" rather than a natural calamity. He also alleged corruption and structural deficiencies in the expressway project.

Elsewhere, heavy overnight rain in Himachal Pradesh triggered flash floods, landslides and road blockades. A 14-year-old girl died after being hit by falling rocks. Flash floods blocked the Chamba-Tissa road, disrupted traffic on the Larji-Sainj road in Kullu and damaged roads, footbridges, playgrounds and farmland in Shimla district. Jogindernagar recorded the state's highest rainfall at 97 mm, followed by Kangra with 74.8 mm. The IMD issued an orange warning for heavy to very heavy rain in Kangra, Mandi, Shimla and Solan districts.

In Jammu and Kashmir, overnight rain caused flash floods that damaged the Doda-Kishtwar highway and buried several vehicles near the under construction 540 MW Kwar Hydroelectric Project in Kishtwar district. Large quantities of mud, rocks and debris covered the highway, trapping heavy machinery and construction equipment. No casualties were reported.

Odisha remained under state-wide alert as rain continued for a third consecutive day under the influence of a depression. The IMD warned of more heavy to very heavy rain through Tuesday and advised fishermen not to venture into the sea. Schools and colleges remained closed in several districts, including Cuttack, Sambalpur, Kandhamal, Bargarh and Sonepur. Twelve locations recorded more than 200 mm of rainfall in the previous 24 hours, with Sonepur receiving 328.4 mm. Waterlogging, uprooted trees and damage to roads and bridges were reported across the state.

The weather system over Odisha is expected to spread heavy rainfall into Jharkhand over the next four days. Thunderstorms, lightning, gusty winds and isolated heavy rain have been forecast across all 24 districts, although the state continues to face a 42 per cent rainfall deficit this monsoon season.

In Arunachal Pradesh, heavy rain continued over eastern districts, prompting alerts for Nam-sai and Lohit, while the Itanagar Capital Region issued a heat wave advisory. Rajasthan also recorded isolated heavy rain, with Shrimadhapur in Sikar district receiving 75 mm. The IMD said the southwest monsoon is likely to remain active across several parts of the state during the coming week.

Delhi escaped major rainfall but remained under uncomfortable weather conditions. The city recorded a maximum temperature of 38.6 degrees Celsius, making it the warmest July day in two years after July 11, 2024, when the temperature reached 38.8 degrees Celsius. High humidity pushed the apparent temperature close to 50 degrees Celsius in several areas, making outdoor conditions extremely uncomfortable.

## Long-term strategic ties

slowdown is unlikely to overshadow the long-term strategic importance of the relationship. Bilateral discussions are expected to focus on creating resilient supply chains and

expanding cooperation in sectors that are increasingly critical to both economies.

Indonesia is among the world's leading producers of nickel, a key raw material used in electric vehicle (EV) batteries, making it an important partner for India's clean energy and mobility ambitions. Alongside critical minerals, both countries are expected to explore collaboration in renewable energy, manufacturing, logistics and industrial value chains.

"President Prabowo and I will visit the Prambanan Temple complex in Yogyakarta. This will ensure closer cultural linkages between our nations. While in Indonesia, I also look forward to interacting with the Indian community," he added.

The centuries-old temple, located approximately 17 kilometres northeast of Yogyakarta city, is considered Indonesia's largest Hindu temple.

Ahead of his departure from Delhi, Modi said his visit to Indonesia, Australia and New Zealand will further strengthen India's Act East Policy, MAHASAGAR Vision as well as "our outlook towards a free and open Indo-Pacific."

MAHASAGAR, or Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security Across the Regions, is India's vision of security and growth for all regions.

Modi's visit comes after President Prabowo's state visit to India as the chief guest at the Republic Day celebrations in January 2025. "India and Indonesia share strong civilisational and people-to-people ties, and my visit will further deepen all aspects of our multifaceted partnership," he said.

From Indonesia, Modi will travel to Melbourne at the invitation of Australian Prime Minister Anthony Albanese. The final leg of the tour will take him to Auckland at the invitation of New Zealand Prime Minister Christopher Luxon.

## Amit Shah

visit, along with Adhikari, to veteran Bengali actor Prosenjit Chatterjee's Ballygunge residence. BJP leaders Locket Chatterjee and Nisith Pramanik were also present. The meeting, which was not part of Shah's official itinerary, has fuelled speculation over a possible Rajya Sabha nomination for the Padma Shri awardee.

Addressing a public meeting at Milan Mela Prangan, Shah said Mookerjee had opposed the Nehru-Liaquat Pact for failing to safeguard Hindus in East Pakistan and asserted that the Citizenship (Amendment) Act had fulfilled his vision by granting citizenship to persecuted Hindus. He also said the abrogation of Article 370 realised Mookerjee's long-standing demand for full integration of Jammu and Kashmir.

Praising the Adhikari government, Shah highlighted the roll-out of central welfare schemes, the passage of the Anti-Goonada Bill, steps towards implementing a Uniform Civil Code, corruption probes, and measures against illegal infiltration. He warned that those found guilty of corruption would face action once inquiry reports were submitted.

## Two Assam Rifles

A senior police officer said the two personnel who died on the spot were a warrant officer and a driver.

Additional security forces were rushed to the area after the ambush, and an exchange of fire later broke out between central forces and armed militants nearby. The site has been cordoned off, while a forensic team from Imphal has been sent to inspect the area. Locals alleged that several farmers working in nearby paddy fields during the firing were detained for questioning.

Chief Minister Y Khemchand Singh condemned the attack and offered condolences to the families of the slain personnel. "Culprits responsible for the murder will be arrested and punished as per the law of the land," he said.

More than 260 people have been killed and thousands displaced in ethnic violence between Meiteis and Kuki-Zo groups since May 2023.

## Hafiz Saeed

The probe agency said the supplementary chargesheet contains details of Pakistan's alleged conspiracy, Saeed's role in the attack and evidence gathered through scientific investigation and extensive ground examination.

Saeed, who is recognised as the mastermind of the 2008 Mumbai attacks that claimed 166 lives, is designated a global terrorist by the United Nations Security Council, India and the United States. He co-founded LeT in the late 1980s and later established charity fronts, including Jamaat-ud-Dawa and the Falah-e-Insaniyat Foundation, which investigators say were used to raise funds and support terror activities.

The latest filing follows the NIA's original 1,597-page chargesheet submitted on December 15 last year. That chargesheet named Pakistani handler Sajid Jatt, three terrorists killed during Operation Mahadev in July 2025, and two arrested accused, Parvaiz Ahmad and Bashir Ahmad Jothar, who allegedly provided logistical support. It also named the banned LeT/TRF as a legal entity.

The April 22, 2025, attack in Pahalgam killed 25 tourists and one local civilian in what the NIA described as religion-based targeted killings. The case, initially registered by the Jammu and Kashmir Police, was later transferred to the NIA by the Ministry of Home Affairs. The agency said its investigation is continuing to uncover the full cross-border conspiracy.

## Sri Lanka

Around 1800 inmates were in the jail when the clashes erupted, officials said.

Preliminary findings have revealed that the violence is believed to have erupted between a group allegedly supporting drug trafficking activities within the prison and another group opposed to such activities.

Security has been significantly strengthened, with the Police Special Task Force (STF) and riot control units deployed to contain the situation.

Following the clashes, three inmates were transferred to the Pallansena Prison Camp on Monday as part of efforts to restore order and prevent further violence, authorities said.

Prisons Department Media Spokesman AC Gajanayake stated that a special investigation has been launched into the incident.

He said a dedicated investigation team has been appointed on the instructions of the Commis-

sioner General of Prisons to conduct a comprehensive inquiry into the causes and circumstances surrounding the unrest.

A separate police investigation is also underway.

A magisterial inquiry into the incident was conducted on Sunday.

## Microsoft cuts

year that began last week. The company is also spinning off four video game development studios previously acquired by Microsoft.

The Xbox cuts are in addition to broader Microsoft layoffs that the software giant's chief people officer Amy Coleman tied to unspecified changes in customer needs.

"I also want to be direct that the roles eliminated today are not being replaced by AI," Coleman wrote in a blog post.

The layoffs followed voluntary buyouts that Microsoft began offering to about 8,750 people in May. More than 30 per cent of eligible workers accepted those voluntary retirement offers, Coleman said Monday.

## Review cash transfer

and broadly consistent improvements" in beneficiaries' savings and spending. Month-end account balances rose by about 84 per cent in Maharashtra and 45 per cent in Odisha, translating into gains of around Rs 6,884 and Rs 6,887 per beneficiary, respectively.

Monthly consumption increased by 46 per cent in Maharashtra and 28 per cent in Odisha, with the paper estimating a marginal propensity to consume of about 0.90.

The study also found benefits extending beyond the recipients. Under Odisha's Subhadra Yojana, a 10 per cent increase in beneficiaries' account balances was linked to a 1.9 per cent decline in relatives' spending. In Maharashtra, relatives' month-end balances increased by 23 per cent while their spending fell by 49 per cent.

The paper recommended that both schemes continue while gradually adopting a "cash-plus" model that combines financial assistance with voluntary skill development, digital literacy and self-help group linkages.

It also noted changes in spending patterns, with greater spending on education, healthcare and lifestyle needs alongside higher UPI usage. In Maharashtra, education-related ATM expenditure rose from 18 per cent to 24 per cent, while lifestyle-related UPI spending increased from 37 per cent to 42 per cent and medical spending from 8 per cent to 10 per cent.

The report said women-focused cash transfer programmes have become one of the fastest-growing areas of state welfare spending. By FY26, more than 15 states had introduced such schemes, reaching nearly 12 crore women at an estimated annual cost of about Rs 1.7 lakh crore. The number of states operating these programmes increased more than fivefold between FY23 and FY26, reflecting growing evidence that direct income support to women can improve household welfare, strengthen financial inclusion and reduce economic inequality.



LAUDS WEST BENGAL GOVT FOR HONOURING HIM

# Article 370 abrogation fulfilled Syama Prasad Mookerjee’s dream, says PM

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Monday said the abrogation of Article 370 had fulfilled the dream of Bharatiya Jana Sangh founder Syama Prasad Mookherjee, while asserting that his ideology and principles continue to shape the BJP's governance agenda and guide "New India".

Addressing a commemorative programme through a video message on Mookerjee's 125th birth anniversary, Modi described him as a visionary, patriot and champion of national unity, and drew a direct ideological link between the Jana Sangh founder's political struggles and several of the BJP's signature policy decisions, including the revocation of Jammu and Kashmir's special status.

"Today, the nation and West Bengal are remembering a great son of the soil, a great



Prime Minister Narendra Modi speaks on the 125th birth anniversary of Bharatiya Jana Sangh founder Syama Prasad Mookerjee, in a virtual address PTI

patriot who was dedicated to the integrity of India," Modi said.

In remarks carrying strong political overtones, the Prime Minister linked several key ideological milestones of the BJP to Mookerjee's vision, particu-

Highlights

- » Modi described Mookerjee as a visionary, patriot and champion of national unity
- » Modi said Mookerjee had fought against the concept of "two constitutions, two heads and two symbols" within one country
- » Mookerjee died on June 23, 1953, while in detention in Srinagar. He was arrested for entering Jammu and Kashmir without the mandatory permit

larly the Centre's August 2019 decision to revoke Jammu and Kashmir's special constitutional status.

"By abrogating Article 370, we have fulfilled the dream of Syama Prasad Mookerjee," Modi said.

Recalling Mookerjee's Opposition to the special constitutional arrangement for Jammu and Kashmir, Modi said he had fought against the concept of "two constitutions, two heads and two symbols" within one country.

The constitutional arrangement allowed the state to maintain its own constitution, fly a separate state flag, and use distinct titles for its leaders -- Prime Minister, and not the chief minister, and Sadar-e-Riyasat in place of governor.

Mookerjee died on June 23, 1953, while in detention in Srinagar. He was arrested for entering Jammu and Kashmir without the mandatory permit.

"Mookerjee was completely dedicated to the vision of Akhand Bharat," he said.

The Prime Minister used the occasion to underscore Mookerjee's role during the

Partition, particularly in safeguarding the interests of Bengal at a time when, according to him, efforts were being made to take the entire province into Pakistan.

"In 1947, when the country was partitioned, conspiracies were being devised to separate the entire region of Bengal from the country. Mookerjee stood firm against these conspiracies. He mobilised public opinion, fought politically and ensured that Bengal remained an integral part of India," Modi said.

"The Congress divided the country, and I divided Pakistan," the PM quoted Mookerjee.

Modi repeatedly highlighted the role of the new BJP government in West Bengal in commemorating the Jana Sangh founder, describing it as a sign of a government committed to a "Nation First" approach.

## TMC submits detailed response to ECI, calls rival camp 'fraudulent'

'Rivals will be defeated in court and before people'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI/KOLKATA: The Mamata Banerjee-led Trinamool Congress on Monday submitted a detailed response, along with supporting documents, to the Election Commission of India (ECI) in New Delhi over the rival faction's claim to the party's name and twin-flower symbol.

Calling the rival faction's claim over the party invalid, TMC submitted that according to the party's constitution, the organisational committees would remain valid till 2027. Party MPs Kalyan Banerjee, Mahua Moitra and Sagarika Ghose visited the Commission's office in New Delhi and filed the reply.

Speaking to reporters after submitting the response, TMC MP Kalyan Banerjee said the party had filed a "very detailed reply" to the Election Commission in response to a representation made by rebel leader Ritabrata Banerjee. Banerjee said the submission included a letter from party chairperson Mamata Banerjee, along with



Kalyan Banerjee, Mahua Moitra and Sagarika Ghose after coming out of ECI office PTI

documents detailing the formation of the Trinamool Congress in 1997 and the evolution of the party's constitution. He said records of the organisational elections held in 2022, in which Mamata Banerjee was elected as the party chairperson, were also submitted to the Commission.

Rejecting the rival camps' claim that the party's working committee had ceased to exist after three years, Banerjee said that the party constitution had been amended over the years to extend the tenure from three years to four years in 2000 and subsequently to five years in 2006, with the changes communicated to the Election Com-

mission. Accordingly, he said, Mamata Banerjee's present tenure as party chairperson remains valid until 2027.

He argued that the rebel leaders had contested the 2026 West Bengal Assembly elections on the Trinamool symbol authorised by Mamata Banerjee. "If they say the party ceased to exist after 2025, then on what basis did they contest the election? Their own argument would make their election illegal. They should resign immediately," said Banerjee.

Calling the actions of the Ritabrata camp "completely fraudulent", he alleged that the rival faction had violated the party constitution by bypassing mandatory organisational procedures and notices. Banerjee asserted that its entire exercise was legally untenable. He also accused the group of acting with the backing of the BJP and Suwendu Adhikari.

Throwing down the gauntlet, Banerjee said the Trinamool Congress would defeat the rival faction "both in the court of law and in the court of the people".

## Ram temple donation row exposed power struggle within BJP: Akhilesh

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav on Monday questioned why the alleged theft of donations at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya was being investigated by a Special Investigation Team (SIT) instead of central agencies such as the CBI, ED or the Income Tax Department, alleging that an internal power struggle within the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) was behind the decision.

Addressing reporters, Yadav said the decision to entrust the case to an SIT reflected a tussle between two centres of power within the BJP, one in Lucknow and the other in Delhi.



Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav addresses a press conference, in Lucknow, Monday PTI

"You have not understood my point about the ED, CBI and Income Tax. I am talking about a power struggle. If the ED, CBI or Income Tax had been brought into the inves-

tigation, who would have controlled the probe? Before the Delhi leadership could take any step, the Lucknow camp took everything under its control. What is this SIT and to whom will its report be submitted?" he said.

The former Uttar Pradesh chief minister said the very fact that an SIT was constituted instead of involving central agencies raised questions about who wanted to retain control over the investigation.

He alleged that the temple's offerings and donations had fallen into the hands of "a gang of thieves" and claimed that those responsible were unable to face public anger.

## 'Self-styled Vishwaguru's stony silence' on Israel unconscionable: Congress slams PM Modi

NEW DELHI: The "self-styled, award-hungry Vishwaguru's stony silence" on Israel's actions is a betrayal of India's civilisational ethos and is simply "unconscionable", the Congress said on Monday in a scathing attack against Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

The Opposition party's statement came after Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu cited support from India, countering American Vice President J D Vance's remarks that the US was its sole powerful ally.

"Mr Netanyahu is wrong. Undoubtedly, Israel is embedded in the Modani empire and Mr Narendra Modi is blindly devoted to him. But crores of Indians condemn Israel's

Closer Look

» Netanyahu told the Fox News Sunday Briefing earlier that Israel has the support of many other

countries, including a small country called India

» Netanyahu said he was getting a lot of support from India on Facebook

genocide in Gaza that has not spared even children, its forcible dispossession and displacement of Palestinians in the occupied West Bank, its heavy aerial bombardments of Iran that has included targeted assassinations, and its brutal military offensive in southern Lebanon. These are all assaults on humanity itself," Congress leader Jairam Ramesh said.

"The self-styled, award-hungry Vishwaguru's stony silence on Israel's actions is a

betrayal of India's civilisational ethos and values. It is simply unconscionable," Ramesh asserted.

Getting a certificate from Netanyahu is no badge of honour, especially since he himself is isolated and has evoked frustration and anger even from Mr. PM Modi's good friend in the White House himself, Ramesh said, in an apparent reference to US President Donald Trump.

Netanyahu told the Fox

News Sunday Briefing earlier that Israel has the support of many other countries, including a small country called India.

"We have some other friends, like a small country called India, you know, it has 1.4 billion people and, boy, do we have tremendous support there," Netanyahu said.

Netanyahu said he was getting a lot of support from India on Facebook.

In a blistering attack on the Modi government, Congress leader Sonia Gandhi last month said its "stony silence" and inaction on Israel's Gaza genocide are not just morally reprehensible but also inexplicable from a national interest perspective.

## UP Cabinet approves plan to set up Startup Mission Directorate

OUR CORRESPONDENT

LUCKNOW: Uttar Pradesh Cabinet on Monday approved the proposal to set up a dedicated Startup Mission Directorate to strengthen the state's startup ecosystem and improve coordination among incubators and Centres of Excellence.

Briefing reporters after the Cabinet meeting, chaired by Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, Information Technology and Electronics Minister Sunil Sharma said the new directorate would be established as a government-registered society to provide focused support to startups.

"The Cabinet has approved the proposal for the formation of the Uttar Pradesh Startup Mission Directorate to establish better coordination among incubators and Centres of Excellence and to further increase the number of registered startups in the state," Sharma said.

He said startup-related activities are currently handled by the Uttar Pradesh Electronics Corporation, but the new directorate would function as a separate entity headed by a Chief Executive Officer (CEO) with its own officers and staff.

The Cabinet also approved the Uttar Pradesh Startup Policy-2026, replacing the previous one, Sharma said.

Under the new policy, every selected startup will receive a monthly sustenance allowance of Rs 20,000 for two years, he said.

Besides, the government will provide a prototype grant of up to Rs 10 lakh, seed capital of Rs 15 lakh, and up to Rs 50 lakh in special cases.

The policy also provides for a matching grant of up to Rs 5 crore, while financial assistance for Centres of Excellence has been increased from Rs 10 crore to Rs 12 crore, the minister said.

## Cooperation ministry completes five years with reforms, new initiatives

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: Union Home Minister and Cooperation minister Amit Shah on Monday said that the ministry has ushered in a new era for India's cooperative movement by introducing institutional reforms, harnessing technology and creating new national level institutions for uplifting rural India and farmers.

Speaking on the occasion of the ministry's fifth foundation day celebrations here, Shah said that the formation of Ministry of Cooperation in 2021 put an end to the long-due neglect of the cooperative movement, and gave a new hope and mission to more than 32 crore national



cooperative members and more than 8.5 lakh cooperative institutions in the country.

"During the past five years, the ministry has made a beginning in pursuing governance reforms, development of Primary Agricultural Credit Societies (PACS), cooperative credit, market linkages, and circular economy," he said. The ministry has completed the work of preparing an integrated national database of 8.58 lakh coopera-

tive societies for better planning and policy formulation.

Noting significant achievements at the grassroots level, he said, 50,000 PACS have been computerised as e-PACS in the past five years, while 55,000 societies are providing more than 300 citizen services through Common Service Centres. In addition, thousands of PACS have expanded their business to include agricultural produce, Jan Aushadhi Kendras, petrol pumps, and water supply.

"The banking sector reforms have played a significant role in reducing non-performing assets and have facilitated digital transactions which have helped in building public trust," he said.

## Khattar hands over sanction letters to 31 PMAY-U 2.0 beneficiaries

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Union Minister for Power and Housing & Urban Affairs Manohar Lal Khattar said that Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision is that every poor family should have a permanent house of its own.

He said that the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana-Urban (PMAY-U) 2.0 is a significant step towards realising this commitment.

Addressing a programme organised under PMAY-U 2.0 at the auditorium of the Karnal Municipal Corporation on Monday, the Union Minister said that under the Prime Minister's leadership, the Central

government is committed to providing dignified housing to every eligible family.

He said that owning a home is a lifelong dream for every individual, and that a house is not merely a structure of four walls but the foundation of a family's dignity, security and a better future. He added that the government is working with complete dedication to ensure that the benefits of welfare schemes reach the last person in the queue.

On the occasion, Manohar Lal Khattar distributed sanction letters to 31 beneficiaries under the scheme.

The Union minister said that PMAY-U 2.0 was launched on September 1, 2024, to pro-

vide permanent houses to economically weaker and eligible families. He said that the Central and Haryana governments are jointly implementing several welfare schemes aimed at improving the living standards of poor families.

He emphasised that the government's priority is to ensure that every eligible person receives the benefits of the scheme without discrimination. To achieve this, the entire process has been made transparent and online. He urged beneficiaries to complete the construction of their houses within the stipulated timeframe and make proper use of the financial assistance provided by the government.

## Ayodhya: Faith remains unshaken but questions linger over temple donation scam allegations

Residents and pilgrims awaited outcome of Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust meeting

MPOST BUREAU

AYODHYA: The familiar chants of "Jai Shri Ram" echoed through Ayodhya on Monday, but beneath the devotional fervour ran a quiet undercurrent of anxiety as residents and pilgrims awaited the outcome of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust meeting convened amid allegations of embezzlement of temple donations.

Across the temple town, television screens remained tuned to news channels while mobile phones stayed glued to people's hands. Shopkeepers refreshed news feeds between attending to customers, priests discussed developments in hushed tones, and pilgrims paused outside tea stalls, hoping for updates from the meeting that many believe could restore the confidence of devotees.

The mood outside the temple was markedly subdued.

Lata Mangeshkar Chowk, usually teeming with tourists clicking photographs, had only a scattering of visitors. Along Ram Path, small groups of pil-



A seer watches news amid the ongoing probe into the alleged theft of temple donations, in Ayodhya, Monday PTI

grims walked quietly under the afternoon sun as rows of shops selling prayer items, prasads, sweets and souvenirs waited for customers.

Restaurants that often buzz with pilgrims wore an unusually empty look.

Some traders attributed the thin footfall to the oppressive weather. The air was heavy with humidity and warm winds, while patches of dark clouds occasionally softened the harsh sunlight.

Others, however, said the

decline in visitors had become noticeable since news of the alleged donation theft surfaced last month.

For many, the allegations have been difficult to comprehend.

"We never imagined that people could steal money offered at the feet of Lord Ram. This is not just theft; it has hurt the sentiments of millions of devotees," said a shopkeeper near Ram Path, adding that those found guilty should face the strictest punishment.

Key Points

- » The mood outside the temple was markedly subdued
- » Restaurants that often buzz with pilgrims wore an unusually empty look
- » For many, the allegations have been difficult to comprehend

Visitors, too, admitted the controversy had left them conflicted.

"We had planned to make a donation after offering prayers. Now we are thinking of giving that money to an old-age home instead. If even donations made in a temple are not secure, it makes you think twice," said Virendra Kumar, a devotee from Madhya Pradesh, while stressing that his faith in Lord Ram remained unshaken.

For Someshwar Das, an elderly priest of the Vairagi Akhara, the arrests made so far are only the beginning.

"The government has recov-

ered cash from the accused who have been arrested, but they are all small players in this theft. We hope the trust meeting will not stop there. It should decide to act against the big people behind this scam as well," he said, voicing a sentiment shared by many in the temple town.

Yet, amid the disappointment, faith remained unwavering.

"Lord Ram is watching everything. Nothing remains hidden from him forever. It is because of his will that this theft has come to light. Those responsible, however influential they may be, will receive the punishment they deserve," said Nitin Pandey, another local resident, looking towards the temple.

Security was visibly heightened across the temple town ahead of the trust meeting. Police personnel were deployed in large numbers around the Ram Janmabhoomi complex and key intersections, while barricades were erected at several locations to regulate the movement of vehicles and pedestrians.

## Nation Briefs

### BJP MLA TERON UNANIMOUSLY ELECTED DEPUTY SPEAKER OF ASSAM ASSEMBLY

GUWAHATI: First-time BJP MLA Habbey Teron was on Monday unanimously elected as the Deputy Speaker of the 16th Assam Legislative Assembly. Speaker Ranjeet Kumar Dass announced that there were three nominations in favour of Teron, and no one contested him. "As there is no other nomination, I declare Habbey Teron as the Deputy Speaker of the 16th Assam Legislative Assembly," he added. Teron is an MLA from the newly formed Amri constituency, which came into existence after the delimitation exercise of 2023. After his election, leaders from all political parties, including BJP, AGP, BPF, Congress and TMC congratulated Teron and offered their full cooperation for his tenure.

### FORMER CPI(M) LEADER SASI JOINS UDF ALLY CMP

PALAKKAD: Former CPI(M) leader P K Sasi, who quit the party ahead of the Assembly elections and later contested as a UDF-backed Independent candidate from Ottapalam, on Monday joined the CMP, a constituent of the UDF. Transport minister and Communist Marxist Party (CMP) leader C P John announced Sasi's entry into the party after attending a convention of the Democratic Marxist Party (DMF), which Sasi floated after leaving the Left party. The DMF will now merge with the CMP. Speaking to reporters here, John said Sasi, who is a former MLA, would be inducted as one of the party secretaries. He said the CMP would formally welcome Sasi and the leaders of the DMF during its 40th foundation day celebrations in Thrissur on July 27.



PROJECT 17A GETS 6TH WARSHIP

# Navy set to commission indigenous stealth frigate ‘Mahendragiri’ on July 11

MPOST BUREAU

**NEW DELHI:** Indigenous stealth frigate ‘Mahendragiri’, endowed with state-of-the-art weapons, including surface-to-surface and surface-to-air missile systems, and a cutting-edge sensor suite, is set to be commissioned into the Indian Navy on July 11, officials said on Monday.

Designed by the Navy’s Warship Design Bureau (WDB) and built by MDL Mumbai, ‘Mahendragiri’ is the sixth ship of the Nilgiri-class (Project 17A). It is capable of undertaking anti-air, anti-surface and anti-submarine operations, and is equally suited for maritime security, power projection, humanitarian assistance and disaster relief (HADR), search and rescue, and sustained presence missions, a Navy spokesperson said. “The frigate is equipped with an advanced suite of indigenous and state-of-the-art weapons and sensors, including surface-to-surface and surface-to-air missile systems, sophisticated electronic warfare capabilities, comprehensive anti-submarine warfare systems and an integrated combat management system,” the official said.

Incorporating advanced stealth features, enhanced survivability, reduced radar signature and a high degree of automation, the frigate is powered by a modern Combined Diesel or Gas (CODOG) propulsion system, enabling high-speed operations with “exceptional endurance across the full spectrum of maritime missions”. “With over 75 per cent indigenous content, ‘Mahendragiri’ exemplifies



## HIGHLIGHTS

- » Designed by the Navy’s Warship Design Bureau (WDB) and built by MDL Mumbai, ‘Mahendragiri’ is the sixth ship of the Nilgiri-class (Project 17A)
- » It is capable of undertaking anti-air, anti-surface and anti-submarine operations

the government of India’s Aatmanirbhar Bharat initiative,” the Navy said. Named after the Mahendragiri mountain range in the Eastern Ghats, the frigate embodies resilience, strength and unwavering resolve, the Indian Navy said.

It will serve as a “formidable force multiplier, safeguarding the nation’s maritime interests and contributing to a secure, stable and prosperous Indo-Pacific,” the Navy said.

The frigate was delivered on April 30 at Mazagon Dock Shipbuilders Limited (MDSL), Mumbai. Its construction has brought together a vast network of Indian industries, including numerous Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs), generating employment while strengthening the nation’s defence industrial base, it said.

The commissioning of this

frigate marks another significant milestone in the successful execution of the Project 17A programme. The ships under this programme are fitted with an advanced weapon and sensor suite as compared to the P17 (Shivalik-class).

Indigenous stealth frigate ‘Dunagiri’, the fifth ship of Nilgiri-class (Project 17A) frigates, power packed with state-of-the-art weapon and sensor suites and engineered for sustained operations, was commissioned into the Indian Navy in Kolkata on June 21.

The frigate, along with two other frontline platforms -- Survey Vessel (Large) ‘San-shodhak’ and the fourth of the Arna-class Anti-Submarine Warfare Shallow Water Craft, ‘Agray’, were commissioned into the naval force in the presence of Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

INS Nilgiri, the lead ship of P17A frigates, was commissioned on January 15, 2025. INS Udaygiri and INS Himgiri were commissioned into the Navy on August 26, 2025.

INS Taragiri, the fourth potent platform of the Project 17A class endowed with a cutting-edge weapon suite, including supersonic missiles, was commissioned into the Navy in the presence of Defence Minister Rajnath Singh at Visakhapatnam, Andhra Pradesh, on April 3.

# India says BRICS nations must cooperate ‘more closely’ to combat drug trafficking

BRICS Heads of Anti-Drug Agencies Meeting begins in Guwahati

NARESH BISWANI

**GUWAHATI:** India has called for enhanced collaboration among BRICS nations to address the increasing scourge of narcotic trafficking, suggesting the creation of a virtual working group to share actionable intelligence and mount united operations against transnational drug cartels.

Speaking at the inauguration of the two-day BRICS Heads of Anti-Drug Agencies Meeting here on Monday, the head of the Indian delegation observed that the expanded BRICS outreach has opened up new vistas of opportunity for the grouping to collectively address emerging challenges, including the menace of drug trafficking. India’s head of the delegation at the anti-narcotics meet said the grouping, which has acquired the status of a geopolitical and geo-eco-



nomic giant, covers nearly half of the world’s population and has the resources and resolve to take on the challenge of combating drug trafficking, which has acquired unprecedented dimensions.

“The challenge of drug trafficking has acquired a formidable dimension and the modus operandi of the traffickers keeps evolving. Given that the problem is no longer confined within the borders of individual countries, it is imperative that we enhance synergy between our enforcement agencies,” he said, add-

# Security concerns: ZEE5 told to take down ‘Satluj’

**NEW DELHI:** The Centre has directed OTT platform ZEE5 to remove the Diljit Dosanjh-starrer Satluj, a film based on the life of human rights activist Jaswant Singh Khalsa, citing security concerns and provisions of the Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules, 2021, government sources said on Monday.

Unlike theatrical releases, OTT content is not regulated by the Central Board of Film Certification (CBFC) and falls under the IT Rules, 2021. According to government officials, the film was originally submitted to the CBFC in 2022 under the title Punjab 95. However, the producers did

not accept the 127 cuts recommended by the censor board and did not proceed with a theatrical release. Officials said the film was later released on ZEE5 under the new title Satluj without the suggested edits. After the government became aware of the release, the platform was directed to remove it, citing security concerns and its obligations under the intermediary guidelines.

Directed by Honey Trehan, the film chronicles Khalsa’s investigation into the cremation of thousands of unidentified bodies in Punjab between 1984 and 1994. Khalsa was abducted in 1995 and never seen again. ZEE5 confirmed that the film is no longer available for streaming in India. PTI

## BRICS WWG meet begins in Kochi

**NEW DELHI:** India on Monday began the two-day BRICS Women’s Working Group (WWG) Meeting in Kochi under its BRICS Chairship 2026, with senior officials from member countries deliberating on women’s empowerment and women-led development.

Welcoming the delegates, Women and Child Development Secretary Anil Malik said the shared commitment of BRICS nations had kept them closely connected despite geographical distances. He expressed confidence that the meeting would promote meaningful dialogue and stronger cooperation.

Discussions are centred on four priority areas -- women’s leadership and governance, financial and digital inclusion, entrepreneurship and skill development, and women’s role in climate action, food security and nutrition. MPOST

ing that the rising use of digital platforms, dark web, sea routes, and the introduction of new psychoactive substances by international drug cartels necessitate collective action.

India’s proposal to set up a BRICS Virtual Working Group to enable the member countries

to share actionable intelligence and operate against common targets was endorsed by all. In addition, a proposal to conduct capacity building programs for the enforcement agencies to develop deeper expertise in countering narcotic trafficking was also approved.

# Climate change ‘rewriting’ Himachal Pradesh’s apple map

ASHWANI SHARMA

**SHIMLA:** Climate change is taking a visible toll on Himachal Pradesh’s apple industry, with warmer winters, erratic weather and prolonged dry spells threatening the state’s most valuable horticultural crop. Experts and growers warn that the mountain climate, which once provided ideal conditions for apple cultivation, is rapidly changing, raising concerns over the future of an industry that supports nearly 2.5 lakh families and generates an annual income of around Rs 5,000-5,500 crore.

Former Himachal Pradesh University vice-chancellor and orchardist Rajinder Chauhan said the warning signs had

been evident for years but had now become impossible to ignore. He attributed the sharp decline in production to inadequate winter snowfall, failed rains, unseasonal spring showers, hailstorms, thunderstorms and erratic temperature fluctuations. The state Horticulture Department shares this assessment.

Apple production is expected to fall by 40-48 per cent this year. According to horticulture experts, output may decline from 6.99 lakh metric tonnes in 2025 to around 4.28 lakh metric tonnes in 2026, equivalent to nearly 2.1 crore apple boxes. The department’s figures also show wide fluctuations in production over recent years, highlighting

the growing impact of climate variability.

Apple grower Balwant Justa said the absence of timely snowfall and rainfall had severely affected orchards, while the lack of irrigation facilities left farmers heavily dependent on weather conditions. Growers have urged the government to expand irrigation infrastructure and increase awareness about crop insurance schemes to help offset losses.

Production costs have also risen sharply due to higher prices of pesticides, medicines and farm machinery, further squeezing growers’ incomes. Stone fruits such as apricot, cherry, peach and plum have also suffered due to rising temperatures and adverse weather.

FIRST IN THE COUNTRY

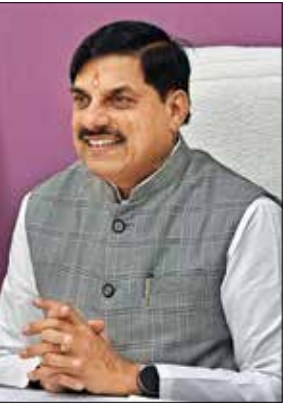
# New MP Waqf Board gets 2 Hindu members

SATYAPRAKASH SHARMA

**BHOPAL:** Under the provisions of the new Waqf Act, the Madhya Pradesh government has reconstituted the State Waqf Board, appointing two Hindu members—Animesh Bhargava and Manoj Malpani—as non-Muslim members.

“Madhya Pradesh has become the first State in the country to reconstitute its Waqf Board under the provisions of the Waqf Act, 1995, as amended in 2025,” the State government said in a statement.

According to a gazette notification issued on July 4 by the Backward Classes and Minority Welfare (BC&MW) Department, the government has constituted a 10-member Board. BJP leader Sanwar



MP CM Mohan Yadav

Patel has been retained as its Chairperson.

The move has, however, drawn criticism from sections of the Muslim community. Congress MLA Arif Masood termed the decision “com-

## Animesh Bhargava and Manoj Malpani appointed as non-Muslim members of the state Waqf Board

pletely wrong”, arguing that the constitutional validity of several provisions of the amended Act is currently under consideration by the Supreme Court.

Masood said he would move the Supreme Court challenging the State government’s decision.

The other members of the Board are former Union Minister Nazma Heptullah, Congress MLA Atif Aqeel, Faizan Khan, Fatema Choudhary,

Shaista Sultan, Shabana Khan, and the Commissioner of the BC&MW Department as an ex officio member.

“For years, the Waqf Board was controlled by the Waqf mafia. I thank Prime Minister Narendra Modi for bringing the new law, which makes it mandatory to include women as well as non-Muslim members as experts. I also thank Chief Minister Mohan Yadav and his government for making Madhya Pradesh the first State to implement the new law,” Patel said.

The Waqf (Amendment) Act, 2025, notified in April 2025, amended Sections 13(1) and 14 of the Waqf Act, 1995, making it mandatory for the Central Waqf Council and State Waqf Boards to include at least two non-Muslim members.

# Hry: Hooda demands rollback of UHSR fee hike



**CHANDIGARH:** Former Haryana Chief Minister and Leader of Opposition Bhupinder Singh Hooda on Monday launched a sharp attack on the BJP government, accusing it of burdening students with steep fee hikes, mishandling recruitment examinations, allowing corruption to flourish and pushing the state into mounting debt.

Addressing a press conference in Rohtak, Hooda alleged that the government had imposed a fee hike of up to 400 per cent for medical and para-medical courses at the University of Health Sciences, Rohtak (UHSR), effective from August 1. He said the move would make higher education unaffordable for aspiring doctors, nurses and pharmacists and urged the government to withdraw the decision.

Hooda also raised concerns over alleged irregularities in the Haryana Teacher Eligibility Test (HTET), claiming candidates had reported incorrect OMR sheets, wrong and unsealed question papers, serial number mismatches and errors in the language of questions. He demanded an impartial probe into the alleged lapses.

Claiming that recruitment irregularities were persisting despite a shortage of teachers, Hooda said 16,435 of the state’s 1,01,499 sanctioned teaching posts remained vacant.

He further alleged that Haryana’s debt had risen sharply under the BJP government, claiming it had increased from around Rs 60,000-70,000 crore before 2014 to nearly Rs 5.5 lakh crore by 2026.

Referring to alleged scams in paddy procurement, the banking sector and the theft case at a Ram temple, Hooda accused the government of attempting to suppress investigations. MPOST

# ‘Misappropriation’ of BRO funds: CBI conducts searches in 11 states & UTs

**NEW DELHI:** The CBI on Monday conducted searches at 26 locations across 11 states and Union territories in connection with four separate cases pertaining to misappropriation of funds of the Border Road Organization (BRO).

The action follows FIRs registered by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) against 10 officers of Lt Col, Major and Engineer ranks, along with certain private persons, officials said.

The searches were carried out in Jammu and Kashmir, Ladakh, Delhi, Haryana, Uttarakhand, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Maharashtra, Assam, Arunachal Pradesh and Nagaland, they said.

“These cases relate to irregularities in deployment of casual labourers and payments

## Bribery case: NHAI Shillong project director arrested

MPOST BUREAU

**NEW DELHI:** The CBI has arrested the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) project director in Shillong and two private persons for allegedly demanding a Rs 12 lakh bribe from a contractor to clear a pending bill of Rs 13.38 crore.

The agency registered the case on July 1 following a complaint against project director Aanand Singh Chouhan.

According to the CBI, the official sought an advance of Rs 4 lakh, which was to be routed through two intermediaries in Guwahati. The agency laid a trap, caught one accused accepting the bribe, and subsequently arrested Chouhan, Punit Agarwal and Manish Agarwal.

released in the name of fake casual labourers in the Project Vijayak and Yojak in the UT of Ladakh,” a CBI spokesperson said in a statement.

The FIRs were registered on complaints by the Defence ministry following an internal enquiry conducted by Technical Board of Officers of BRO. MPOST

# ‘El Nino to hit India’s energy system harder than anywhere else in world’

Cooling demand could total 10 TWh within a year, says CREA report

MPOST BUREAU

**NEW DELHI:** This year’s El Niño will hit India’s energy system harder than anywhere else, according to a new analysis by the Centre for Research on Energy and Clean Air (CREA).

El Niño is the recurrent weather pattern that drives up global temperatures. India faces a dual challenge -- not only will the falling winds and rainfall associated with El Niño cut the country’s power generation from turbines and hydropower, but the warmer temperatures will also drive up demand for power-hungry air conditioning.

The report said additional cooling demand could total 10 TWh within a year -- the equivalent of a quarter of Delhi’s annual electricity use.

The analysis models the impact of the forecast transition from La Nina to El Niño on India’s power sector from July 2026 to June 2027. La Niña is the cold phase of El Niño.

“Combine the lost output from renewables and the

## KEY POINTS

- » El Niño is the recurrent weather pattern that drives up global temperatures
- » India faces a dual challenge -- not only will the falling winds and rainfall associated with El Niño cut the country’s power generation from turbines and hydropower, but the warmer temperatures will also



drive up demand for power-hungry air conditioning

» The 2026 El Niño is a foretaste of extreme weather events that are becoming more common in a warming world

increased demand for power, and India could face a generation gap of nearly 18 TWh (terrawatt hour). Currently, the most likely outcome is a surge in coal-fired power, which would release an estimated 17 million tonnes of CO2.

“In the most severe scenario, the extra coal generation reaches 24 TWh, roughly half of India’s entire increase in coal burn last year,” the analysis said. The 2026 El Niño is a foretaste of extreme weather

events that are becoming more common in a warming world. With El Niño occurring on a two-to-seven-year cycle, the extent to which India can meet or exceed its solar and storage deployment targets is the key metric for grid resilience.

“India has just endured a deadly heatwave and one of its hottest summers on record, pushing power demand to an all-time high of 270 GW. A super El Niño will raise the stakes again -- putting even

more strain on the grid while worsening water shortages and pressure on farming,” the report said. It said India must stay on track for its target of 500 GW of non-fossil power by 2030 but also move much faster on batteries and grid upgrades, so that clean energy can meet future surges in power demand reliably and affordably.

Record demand peaks like the 270 GW set in May are routinely cited to argue the case for new coal capacity. But India’s coal-fired power plants are facing serious challenges in keeping up with the energy demand curve and operating with the flexibility the grid requires throughout the day.

As a result of this inflexibility, grid operators curtailed around 2.1 TWh of solar and wind last year just to keep coal plants running.

The analysis pointed out: “Solar power is playing an ever-increasing role in powering India, now meeting 24 pc of daytime power demand. Solar generation is also far less affected by El Niño...”

# MP: 4 killed, 5 injured as truck collides with SUV

**SEHORE (MP):** Four persons were killed and five others sustained injuries after a truck collided with an SUV in Madhya Pradesh’s Sehore district on Monday, police said.

The collision occurred near Godi Jod on the Ashta-Shujalpur Road around 2.30 pm, an official said. Four people travelling in the SUV were killed on the spot, while five others sustained injuries and were admitted to a hospital, he said.

Police and ambulances arrived at the scene and extricated the victims from the SUV, which was completely mangled due to the impact of the crash, Parvati Police Station in-charge Harisingh Parmar said.

Two of the deceased were identified as Inder Singh and Rajaram, residents of Bhiyapura in Rajgarh district, while police were in the process of ascertaining the identity of the others.

As per preliminary investigations, nine people were travelling in the SUV, transporting a mentally ill person for treatment. MPOST

# Puri Rath Yatra rush: Rlys to operate more than 300 special trains

OUR CORRESPONDENT

**NEW DELHI/BHUBANESWAR:** With lakhs of devotees expected to visit Puri after this month’s annual Rath Yatra, Railways minister Ashwini Vaishnaw on Monday reviewed extensive railway arrangements to ensure safe, smooth and comfortable travel during one of the country’s largest religious gatherings.

During his one-day visit to Odisha, Vaishnaw, accompanied by Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi, inspected passenger facilities and crowd management measures at Puri railway station. Senior railway and district administration officials briefed him on the comprehensive operational plan prepared to handle the expected surge in pilgrims.

Railways has planned to operate more than 300 special trains for the Rath Yatra in addition to over 800 regular train services. To manage the heavy footfall, holding areas with a combined capacity of over 30,000 passengers have been created. Authori-

## Minister Vaishnaw reviews Railways’ preparations

ties have also set up additional ticket counters, enhanced food and drinking water facilities, strengthened passenger assistance services and improved station management to minimise congestion.

The minister reviewed emergency response systems, passenger amenities and safety measures, while directing officials to ensure seamless operations without disrupting regular railway services.

Vaishnaw also flagged off the Puri-Koraput Express, which is expected to improve rail connectivity to southern Odisha and provide better travel options for passengers within the state. He also inaugurated the Brahmapur-Udhna Amrit Bharat Express, a daily service aimed at strengthening direct rail connectivity between Odisha and Gujarat, benefiting both regular commuters and long-distance travellers.





EDITORIAL  
POWER ENTERS  
THE PITCH

The World Cup has always claimed to be more than a sporting tournament. It is a celebration of fair competition, shared rules and the belief that, for 90 minutes, every nation competes on equal terms regardless of its military strength, economic influence or geopolitical weight. That ideal is precisely what makes football the world's most popular sport. Yet ideals are fragile when confronted with political power. The extraordinary decision by FIFA to lift American forward Folarin Balogun's automatic suspension after a reported intervention by United States President Donald Trump has raised troubling questions that extend far beyond one player's availability. Whether the decision was legally permissible under FIFA's disciplinary code is almost secondary. The larger issue is whether global sport can retain its credibility if the political influence of powerful leaders appears capable of altering decisions that affect the outcome of the world's biggest sporting event. Even the perception of such influence is corrosive. Once spectators begin to suspect that rules are negotiable for the influential but rigid for everyone else, the very foundation of sporting legitimacy begins to erode.

Sport has spent decades trying to insulate itself from political interference, though never with complete success. Olympic boycotts, Cold War rivalries, apartheid-era sporting bans and diplomatic disputes have repeatedly demonstrated that politics inevitably shadows international competition. FIFA itself has frequently insisted that governments must not interfere in football administration, even suspending national federations where state influence became excessive. Ironically, that principle appears severely compromised if the head of a powerful government can successfully press for a review of an on-field disciplinary decision during an ongoing World Cup. It matters little whether Trump merely requested a reconsideration or whether FIFA independently concluded that the red card deserved to be suspended. The sequence of events creates an appearance that access to power can produce outcomes unavailable to ordinary federations. Belgium's outrage reflects not merely disappointment over facing a stronger American side but concern that football's governing institutions may be vulnerable to political pressure. Sporting justice depends not only on fairness but also on public confidence that fairness has prevailed. When that confidence weakens, every subsequent decision becomes suspect.

The implications stretch beyond football. Modern sport increasingly exists at the intersection of politics, commerce and diplomacy. Nations invest billions in hosting tournaments because sporting success enhances national prestige. Governments routinely celebrate victories as evidence of national vitality and leadership. That is understandable. What becomes dangerous is when political leaders seek to shape the administration of competitions themselves. If presidents, prime ministers or monarchs begin lobbying governing bodies whenever star athletes receive suspensions, controversial refereeing decisions or disciplinary sanctions, every tournament risks becoming a contest of political leverage rather than athletic excellence. Smaller nations, lacking comparable diplomatic weight, would understandably question whether they compete on an equal playing field. Rules that appear flexible for major powers but inflexible for everyone else undermine the universality that gives international sport its meaning. FIFA's disciplinary code may indeed allow sanctions to be suspended under exceptional circumstances. Yet extraordinary powers require extraordinary transparency. Without a detailed, publicly reasoned explanation demonstrating why this particular case warranted unprecedented treatment, suspicion inevitably fills the vacuum.

The controversy also exposes FIFA's recurring struggle with governance and institutional credibility. For years, the organisation has attempted to rebuild trust following corruption scandals that severely damaged its reputation. Greater financial oversight, ethics reforms and governance changes were meant to convince the football world that decisions would increasingly rest on institutional integrity rather than personal influence. Those efforts risk being overshadowed whenever opaque decision-making produces outcomes that appear tailored to powerful interests. Even if the governing body acted entirely within its legal authority, timing and communication matter enormously. The absence of convincing transparency allows critics to assume political considerations prevailed over sporting principles. That perception is particularly damaging during a World Cup, where every disciplinary ruling can influence millions of supporters and alter the competitive balance of the tournament. Football's governing institutions cannot afford ambiguity when the stakes involve not merely one match but the credibility of the competition itself.

Donald Trump's involvement reflects a broader style of political leadership that frequently embraces direct intervention in institutions traditionally expected to operate independently. Throughout his public career, he has rarely hesitated to publicly influence judicial proceedings, regulatory decisions, corporate disputes or sporting controversies. His supporters interpret such interventions as decisive leadership on behalf of national interests. Critics view them as attempts to personalise institutional decision-making. Regardless of political opinion, international sport cannot function effectively if governing bodies appear responsive to personal appeals from powerful leaders. Every future disciplinary controversy would invite similar lobbying. Other governments would understandably feel compelled to intervene on behalf of their own athletes simply to avoid competitive disadvantage. Such escalation would transform sporting governance into diplomatic negotiation, with fairness increasingly measured by political access rather than consistent application of rules.

Football's enduring appeal lies in its unpredictability. Underdogs defeat giants because, once the whistle blows, influence outside the field is supposed to disappear. A referee's decision may be controversial, a disciplinary ruling may appear harsh, but acceptance ultimately rests upon confidence that identical standards apply to everyone. That confidence is difficult to restore once exceptions appear politically convenient. FIFA now bears the responsibility of demonstrating, through complete transparency and consistent future practice, that its institutions remain governed by rules rather than relationships. Political leaders, however passionate their support for national teams, must recognise that preserving the integrity of international sport sometimes requires restraint rather than intervention. Governments may celebrate victories, invest in infrastructure and encourage participation, but they should never appear to negotiate outcomes. The World Cup belongs not to presidents, governing bodies or commercial interests, but to the millions who believe that on football's greatest stage, merit alone determines success. If that belief weakens, the sport loses something far more valuable than a single match—it loses the trust that makes competition worth watching.

TALKING SHOP



RAJEEV NARAYAN

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External debt was \$762.8 billion in FY 2025-26 and the rupee slipped by 10 per cent. But sovereign debt was lower, with non-financial corporations making up 36 per cent of loans – signalling the jolt of private sector borrowings

REGIONAL PULSE



SHANTANU MUKHARJI

THE WRITER IS A RETIRED IPS OFFICER, ADVISER NATSTRAT, AND A FORMER NATIONAL SECURITY ADVISOR IN MAURITIUS

Recurring protests in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir now reflect deeper concerns over political representation, governance and constitutional legitimacy, challenging Islamabad beyond law-and-order issues

Debt Reckoning

India's rising external debt is as much a reflection of its economic ambition as it is of growing vulnerability in a world that is still being dominated by the dollar

"Debts are like children – begot with pleasure, but brought forth with pain."

— Molière

The numbers are beginning to gain weight. Not merely on paper, but on the economy itself. India's external debt has climbed to \$762.8 billion at the end of FY 2025-26, rising by \$26.3 billion in a year and pushing the country's external debt-to-GDP ratio to 20.8 per cent, from 19.8 per cent earlier.

In another era, these may have remained distant macroeconomic figures tucked away inside Reserve Bank of India documents, discussed only by economists and policy specialists. But in today's turbulent global climate, debt no longer remains confined to balance sheets. It travels through currencies, markets, inflation, imports, corporate earnings and eventually into the everyday anxieties of ordinary citizens.

Today, India's debt position appears manageable for an economy of its scale, especially when compared to other nations burdened by heavy sovereign liabilities. Yet, beneath the statistical calm lies an uneasy reality shaped by a weakening rupee, strengthening US dollar, geopolitical instability, nervous investors and a global financial system that punishes vulnerability with unforgiving speed.

India is not in crisis. But it is entering a phase where external debt can no longer be dismissed as a dry statistic. It is becoming a strategic economic question, one that touches currency stability, investor confidence, inflation, corporate risk and India's room for manoeuvring in an increasingly uncertain world.

Dollar Dominance

The unapologetic reality is the overwhelming dominance of the US dollar in India's debt profile. More than 55 per cent of India's external debt is dollar-denominated, while the Indian rupee accounts for under 30 per cent. The rest is spread across the Japanese yen, SDRs and the euro. Does this matter? Yes, it does, enormously. Because every bout of dollar strengthening unforgivingly makes loan repayment in rupee terms more expensive. And the dollar has been exceptionally strong.

The RBI itself noted that valuation effects caused by dollar appreciation accounted for \$24.6 billion of the increase in India's external debt during FY 2025-26. Tellingly, without these valuation effects, the jack-up in debt would have been a sharper \$51 billion. That distinction is game-changing, because it reveals how vulnerable modern economies have become to global currency movements beyond their direct control.



The present trajectory underlines how enmeshed India is in global capital flows, imported energy and dollar liquidity

For Indian firms borrowing abroad, every rupee weakening phase raises repayment burdens. For import-heavy sectors dependent on crude oil, electronics or machinery, depreciation raises the spectre of operational costs. For the economy, a falling rupee fuels inflation, subsidies and consumer prices.

The consequences are neither theatrical nor theoretical. The rupee's 10-per cent depreciation against the dollar has become a recurring theme during corporate earnings calls, with investors questioning companies about hedging strategies and forex exposure.

Shifting Pressures

The composition of India's external debt deserves scrutiny too. Loans remain the single-largest component, accounting for 34.7 per cent of total debt, followed by currency and deposits at 22.3 per cent, trade credit at 19 per cent and debt securities at 16.1 per cent. Significantly, the recent rise has been driven less by sovereign borrowing and more by private-sector debt. RBI data shows that non-financial corporations account for the largest share of India's external debt, at over 36 per cent.

This reflects an economy that is still investing, expanding and borrowing to grow. However, it also shows that corporate balance sheets are censoriously exposed to global volatility. The real concern lies elsewhere, though – in short-term debt. While long-term debt rose modestly to \$613.5 billion, short-term debt grew faster, from 18.3 per cent to 19.6 per cent of overall debt. Its ratio to India's foreign exchange reserves also climbed, from 20.1 per cent to 21.6 per cent.

That may appear numerical, but markets understand the deeper significance. Short-term debt creates immediate repayment pressure. In times of global instabil-

ity, refinancing such debt is costlier and riskier. A nervous global financial system rarely rewards emerging markets carrying rising short-term obligations.

Mind you, India's situation is far from alarming, given its sizeable forex reserves and comparatively healthy debt-service ratio. In fact, debt servicing as a percentage of current receipts has declined from 6.6 per cent to 5.8 per cent in FY 2025-26 – a sign that repayment capacity remains comfortable. But external debt sustainability is not judged by current comfort alone; it is judged by resilience during stress.

The Global Flight

The broader global climate is making that stress harder to ignore. Across the world, investors are gravitating towards safer assets, stronger currencies and higher-yield markets. US bonds are attractive, tech-linked investments still draw capital and geopolitical uncertainty is pushing investors towards dollar assets. Indian retail and corporate investors are joining this global sheep-walk.

As investors exchange rupees for dollars to fund their overseas investments, the demand for dollars rises and the rupee weakens. The cycle turns self-reinforcing. Export-oriented sectors may benefit for a bit from a weaker currency, but import-heavy sectors face rising costs, volatility and shrinking margins. This is why the RBI finds itself engaged in a tough balancing exercise. It has to manage inflation, maintain liquidity, defend currency stability and support economic growth amid intense external pressures.

Such interventions buy time. They do not eliminate structural pressures. Sure, India is not alone in facing this dilemma. Emerging economies across Asia, Africa and Latin America are battling the same

reality, that of the global financial system principally remaining dollar-centric. The stronger the dollar becomes, the heavier external debt will feel for developing economies.

The Debt Debate

Should India worry? Yes. Is there need to panic? No. India's external debt-to-GDP ratio at 20.8 per cent is moderate by any standards. And it possesses substantial foreign exchange reserves, a growing economy and stable banking fundamentals. Recent RBI assessments have also projected resilience in the financial system despite the global turmoil.

Yet, complacency would be dangerous. The present trajectory underlines how enmeshed India is in global capital flows, imported energy and dollar liquidity. It also reveals the growing dependence of Indian corporates and investors on global markets for financing, returns and strategic positioning.

The Narendra Modi government's emphasis on domestic manufacturing, infrastructure and technology reflects an understanding of this challenge. After all, a country aspiring to become a major economic power cannot indefinitely remain vulnerable to every phase of dollar strengthening or every swing in investor sentiment. The issue is not the size of India's external debt. It is the quality of growth being generated alongside it. If borrowed money builds infrastructure, industries and export strength, debt becomes a tool of expansion. But if economic growth slows while debt rises and the currency weakens, liabilities deepen.

Taciturn Crossroads

India stands in a narrow passage between confidence and caution. Its economy remains among the world's fastest-growing. Its digital infrastructure, manufacturing ambitions and demographic scale continue to attract global optimism. But global finance has become unforgiving, volatile and brutally interconnected. External debt, currency pressures and investor anxiety can no longer be treated as isolated conversations.

The task before India is not to borrow wisely, but to reduce the compulsions that make dependence on foreign capital inevitable in the first place. That means deeper domestic manufacturing, stronger exports, tech competitiveness, energy security and resilience in the rupee. It means building an economy where growth is powered less by external vulnerability and more by internal strength. In the end, debt is rarely dangerous merely because it exists. It gets dangerous only when a nation begins losing control over it.

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PoK's Gathering Storm

Youth-led protests and unresolved constitutional issues are reshaping Pakistan-occupied Kashmir's political landscape, testing Islamabad's control over the sensitive region today



Beneath the uneasy calm, Pakistan-occupied Kashmir remains a tinderbox where even a minor trigger could ignite a wider political crisis

It is relevant to mention that, three years ago, the people took to the streets to protest against the shortage of essential commodities and high electricity tariffs. The situation was brought under control when the administration accepted the people's demands, but other issues continued to simmer. Discontent rose with growing unemployment among the youth, and political manipulation was alleged. The demand for abolishing reserved seats in the PoK Assembly reflected the frustration of a large segment of the local population, who perceived that the government was being run from outside. These facts are well articulated in the leading Pakistani dailies, especially by noted columnist Zahid Hussain in Dawn, the most widely read English newspaper in Pakistan. Last year's protests in September and October compelled the government to negotiate with the protesters. Most of their demands were accepted, and the administration promised to implement them within a stipulated timeframe. These demands primarily focused on the provision of basic socio-economic facilities.

However, a major highlight was the call for the abolition of

the refugee seats, which have long been used by Islamabad to manipulate the political system. The government now claims that it has accepted most of the 38 points raised by the protesters, and both Islamabad and the PoK governments promised to address the issue of reserved seats. However, more than eight months later, no progress has yet been made on this matter, with the simmering political discontent threatening to escalate. This development is now clearly visible.

Meanwhile, reports confirm that several law enforcement personnel and demonstrators were killed in the recent clashes, and the situation was still not under control, contrary to what Islamabad and the local authorities claim. The use of force could alienate the population in this extremely sensitive region, which has significant geopolitical implications for Pakistan. Unfortunately, those in power have yet to understand the gravity of the situation. Dawn also alleged in its recent editorial that a flawed electoral system has long been used to install compliant administrations or unseat those that have fallen out of favour. Under the PoK Interim Constitution of

1974, of the 45 directly elected seats, 33 fall within the geographical boundaries of PoK, while 12 seats are reserved for Kashmiri refugees residing in Pakistan. Six of these 12 seats are allocated to refugees from Jammu, while the remaining six are for refugees from the Indian side of the Kashmir Valley. Geographically, eight of these seats are for Kashmiris residing in Punjab, with the rest divided between Sindh, Balochistan and Khyber Pakhtunkhwa (KP). As is well known in PoK, the number of voters in an electoral constituency ranges from 70,000 to 130,000. In contrast, for the six seats reserved for Jammu refugees, the number of registered voters ranges from 37,000 to 110,000. The total number of voters in the six constituencies reserved for the Kashmir Valley is only 33,000, with individual constituencies having between 3,300 and 7,700 voters, according to the Election Commission's statistics from the 2021 elections.

Since these reserved seats lie outside the geographical and constitutional boundaries of PoK, their existence clashes with the fundamental structure of the Interim Constitution. Furthermore, elections for these seats are not conducted by the Election Commission of PoK but by the Election Commission of Pakistan through the respective provincial administrations, leaving no mechanism for accountability to the PoK Election Commission. Those elected to these reserved seats often lack any genuine stake in the region, and the seats typically go to the ruling party in Islamabad.

Complaints of fraudulent voting in these seats have also been persistent. In the current Assembly, the residency certificates of

four out of the 12 members are reported to be questionable, and investigations are ongoing in the courts. Additionally, one member's State Subject Certificate has been declared fake by the Supreme Court, which ordered action, but no measures have yet been taken. Despite such doubtful credentials, members elected to these reserved seats play a crucial role in the formation of PoK governments, with many becoming ministers despite having no real connection to the region.

In light of these developments, it is not altogether surprising that whichever party is in power in Islamabad typically forms the government in PoK and is subsequently unseated with shifting political dynamics in Pakistan. This political manipulation is reflected in the fact that the region has had four Prime Ministers since the 2021 elections. Last week, the PoK Supreme Court upheld a reference filed by the PoK government, stating that the provision of reserved seats could only be altered through a constitutional amendment. When democratic recourse is closed off, people are left with little choice but to fight for their rights. No force can stop the power of the people, as reflected in the consistent reporting and commentary of the Pakistani mainstream media on this sensitive issue and related developments.

Judging by the recent developments in PoK, the situation appears highly combustible, with the people increasingly restive in their demand for justice and fair play. A single spark in this hyper-sensitive region could push the State into a precarious situation that may not be easy to contain. Views expressed are personal



AUTHORITIES OFFERED NO IMMEDIATE CROWD COUNT

# Mourners throng funeral procession in Tehran for Ayatollah Ali Khamenei

TEHRAN: Mourners dressed in black flooded into Iran's capital Monday for a procession as part of the funeral of the late Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, with throngs of people calling for the death of US President Donald Trump.

Khamenei's flag-draped coffin, and those of his family members who were killed February 28 in an airstrike at the start of the war launched by Israel and the United States, sat aboard a truck decorated to resemble the ornamental grating that surrounds the shrine of an imam.

The massive turnout was encouraged by Iran's theocracy as a sign of strength, and it came as the Islamic Republic negotiates with the US over a permanent end to the war.

Helicopter images aired on Iranian state television showed a massive crowd stretching from Tehran's Azadi, or Freedom, Square for kilometres (miles) down a multilane street of the same name.

The crowd appeared to be larger than the one that turned out for the 2020 procession for the late Revolutionary Guard Gen. Qassem Soleimani, which drew over 1 million people.



The truck carries the coffins of the slain Iranian Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and members of his family makes its way through mourners during the funeral procession in Tehran on Monday

Authorities offered no immediate crowd count as the truck crept down the street. But people alongside the truck and elsewhere on the route carried placards, signs and banners calling for Trump's death.

"Today that we are here for the funeral for our leader, it's a very tough day," mourner

Fatima Hassan said. "We are not here to say goodbye to him. We are here for revenge. And we will take revenge."

Mourners reached out to touch the truck, and some threw scarves and other items for attendants to brush against the coffin, a common practice in Iran seen as a blessing.

Attendants, some on the ladders of fire trucks, sprayed misted water across the crowds to cool them in the heat.

Authorities appeared concerned about the dangers of having a large crowd alongside the procession, with officials on loudspeakers urging the public to walk

## Highlights

- » Khamenei's flag-draped coffin sat aboard a truck decorated to resemble the ornamental grating that surrounds shrine of an imam
- » The crowd appeared to be larger than the one that turned out for the 2020 procession for the late Revolutionary Guard Gen. Qassem Soleimani

slowly, not to push and to stay to the edges of the street.

The coffins were taken through the streets of Tehran on a roughly 12-hour journey to Mehrabad International Airport, where state television footage showed a truck approaching with the caskets.

Authorities have shut down streets, airspace and daily life for the mourning, which began Saturday and will end Thursday as Khamenei is buried at the Imam Reza shrine in Mashhad, his birthplace. Khamenei was 86.

# Russia's missile, drone attacks on Ukraine kill at least 21 people

KYIV: Russia unleashed waves of missiles and drones at Ukraine early Monday, killing at least 21 people in attacks that exposed widening gaps in country's air defences more than four years into Moscow's full-scale invasion, authorities said.

All of the ballistic missiles launched by Russia struck their targets, underscoring Kyiv's need for more US-made Patriot interceptor missiles — a point Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy will likely reiterate at a NATO summit in Ankara, Turkey, this week.

Fifteen people were killed in the capital of Kyiv, which was Russia's main target, and 56 were injured, according to administrative head Tymur Tkachenko.

Another six people were killed in the wider Kyiv region and 21 were injured, according to Mykola Kalashnyk, the head of the regional administration, and other emergency officials.

Emergency workers searched for survivors in the rubble of residential high-rises in two locations that suffered direct hits. Moscow has stepped up strikes on Kyiv in retaliation for Ukraine's recent long-range strikes, according to the Russian Defense Ministry. Those attacks have caused severe fuel shortages and put pressure on President Vladimir Putin.



Emergency services personnel work to extinguish a fire following Russian missile attacks in Kyiv on Monday

## Last week, a Russian strike killed 31 people in Kyiv, the deadliest attack in the capital this year

On Thursday, a Russian strike killed 31 people in Kyiv, the deadliest attack in the capital this year.

Ukraine's advances in drone technology have given it an edge in recent months, analysts and Western officials say, striking supply routes behind the front line, stripping the Russian army of momentum on the battlefield and slowing its advance.

But Russia is now exploiting a different kind of momentum: vulnerability

ties in Ukraine's air defences, which remain heavily reliant on the Patriot missile systems to intercept ballistic missiles it can rarely shoot down.

The war in the Middle East has strained the global supply of Patriot interceptors — a shortage now felt keenly in Ukraine. Ukraine's air force said Russia fired 351 drones and 68 missiles overnight, targeting mainly Kyiv, and all 29 ballistic missiles struck their targets.

"To intercept ballistics, we need the means for interception," air force spokesman Yuriy Ihnat said on national television. "Russians are certainly using the fact that there is a serious deficit of interceptor missiles now, in Ukraine and the world."

# NATO chief demands allies present credible plans to reach defence spending targets

**CHANGE OF NAME**

Know all that my name in High School certificate and records of Punjab & Sind Bank is mistakenly written as Kaushlendra Mohan Shahay and Kaushalendra Mohan Shahay son of Mahima Shanker Shahay whereas my correct name is Kaushlendra Mohan Sahay son of Mahima Shanker Sahay and henceforth, I should be known by my this correct name Kaushlendra Mohan Sahay son of Mahima Shanker Sahay for all purposes whatsoever.

ANKARA: NATO Secretary-General Mark Rutte on Monday demanded that the allies put forward "clear, concrete and credible plans" to reach the organisation's spending targets at its annual summit in Ankara.

Rutte made the remarks in the Turkish capital come ahead of a two-day summit starting on Tuesday that comes at a time crucial time for the alliance with the United States scal-

ing down its security role in Europe.

Washington has been pressing allies to shoulder more of the spending burden.

The 32 nations agreed last year to invest 5 per cent of their gross domestic product on defence — 3.5 per cent on their defence budgets and 1.5 per cent on roads, bridges and ports so troops and equipment can move faster in times of

conflict.

Spain endorsed the goal but said that it could fulfill NATO's security requirements without spending so much. Some countries are still struggling to meet the alliance's old target of 2 per cent of GDP.

Asked what would happen to allies that don't have a clear plan, Rutte said: "If one or two of still have to be convinced, we have ways to do that."

## PPP's Amjad Hussain sworn in as Gilgit-Baltistan CM

ISLAMABAD: Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP) leader Amjad Hussain was sworn in as the so-called chief minister of Pakistan-occupied Kashmir's Gilgit-Baltistan region on Monday.

Hussain, a lawyer by profession, was elected for the role on June 22 after his party emerged as the largest party with 12 seats in the so-called assembly out of 24 contested constituencies.

Earlier, the PPP had announced that it would form a government with the support of the Pakistan Muslim League-Nawaz (PML-N), but the latter decided to sit on the opposition benches.

The elections were held on June 7 to elect 24 members through direct elections. Another eight seats are reserved for women, technocrats and professionals.

# France's Macron visits Syria, 1st western leader since Assad ouster



President Macron was greeted at Damascus airport by Syrian Foreign Minister Asaad al-Shibani

DAMASCUS: French President Emmanuel Macron arrived Monday in Syria, making him the first major western leader to visit the war-torn country since the ouster of Bashar al-Assad in 2024.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy visited in April but Macron is the first leader from western Europe or North America to do so.

The French president's visit comes during a period of relative calm in the Middle East after the monthlong war in Iran and Lebanon. He will travel next to Ankara, Turkey, for the NATO summit, where Syrian President Ahmad al-Sharaa is also expected to attend and hold a high-profile meeting with US President Donald Trump.

Syria's state-run SANA news agency said Macron would visit with a business delegation to discuss regional security as well as business and investment opportunities.

Macron was greeted at Damascus airport by Syrian Foreign Minister Asaad al-Shibani. Macron hosted al-Sharaa in Paris in May 2025, where he urged European and US leaders to lift longstanding sanctions on Damascus. Most

of those sanctions had since been lifted.

Paris supported Syria's new leadership even at a time where others were skeptical of al-Sharaa's Islamist-led rule and former role as the head of the Hayat Tahrir al-Sham militant group, previously linked to al-Qaida.

Western governments were especially concerned about the treatment and inclusion of women and minorities, and whether Syria's new government would transition into a more democratic rule.

Syria has managed to sidestep the region's recent conflicts, but the country is still battered from 13 years of war that left much of it in ruins, drove millions into poverty, and will cost hundreds of billions of dollars to rebuild.

**Office of the Resident Commissioner**  
**Govt. of Jharkhand New Jharkhand Bhawan**  
**Bangla Sahib Road, New Delhi-110001.**

**Notice Inviting Short-Term e-tender**  
e-tenders are invited from reputed interested bidders for providing premises for the accommodation to Security Personnel of Jharkhand Bhawan, New Delhi.  
1. Date of issue of Tender notice in website - 09.07.2026 11:00 AM  
2. Bid Submission start date & time - 09.07.2026 11:00 AM  
3. Bid Submission end date & time - 15.07.2026 06:00 PM  
4. Date & Time of opening of technical bid - 17.07.2026 11:00 AM  
5. Date & Time of opening of financial bid - To be notified when evaluation of technical bid is completed.  
Details & tender document can be downloaded from website-jharkhandtenders.gov.in. Non-commercial entities can register themselves by entering GST No./PAN No. etc. in the place of registration number at registration portal at jharkhandtenders.gov.in, in case registration number is not available.  
Sd/-  
Chief Administrative Officer  
PR.NO.384104 Cabinet(26-27):D

**PHYSICAL POSSESSION NOTICE**  
**ICICI Bank**  
Branch Office: ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi- 110005

The Authorised ICICI Bank Officer under the Securitisation, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued Demand Notices to the borrower(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the Notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said Notice. Having failed to repay the amount, the Notice is issued to the borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described below, by exercising powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules on the below-mentioned dates. The borrower in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property. Any dealings with the property will be subject to charges of ICICI Bank Limited.

| Sr. No. | Name of the Borrower(s)/ Loan Account Number                                                                           | Description of Property/ Date of Physical Possession                                                                                                                                                  | Date of Demand Notice/ Amount in Demand Notice (Rs) | Name of Branch                      |
|---------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|
| 1.      | Meenu Meenu/ Sonu Bansal/ LBVGR00006973317 / LBVGR00006973352 / LBVGR00007062575 / TBVGR00006965130 / TBVGR00007059932 | Plot No. 12, Waka Jain Colony, Within Municipal Limits, Ppid No. 1kjurg6 Khewat/ Khatoani No. 73/77 Khasra No. 21/23/3 Jain Colony Joria, Tehsil Jagodhr, Yamuna Nagar, Haryana 135001, 03 July, 2026 | December 30, 2025 Rs. 58,11,474.66/-                | Delhi & Ncr / Yamunanagar (Haryana) |

The above-mentioned borrowers(s)/guarantors(s) is/are hereby issued a 30 day Notice to repay the amount, else the mortgaged properties will be sold after 30 days from the date of publishing this Notice, as per the provisions under Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002.  
Date: July 07, 2026 Place: Delhi & Ncr Sincerely Authorised Officer, For ICICI Bank Ltd.

**Chhattisgarh State Industrial Development Corporation Limited**  
(A Government of Chhattisgarh Undertaking)  
1<sup>st</sup> Floor, Udyog Bhawan, Ring Road No.1, Telibandha, Raipur(C.G.) – 492006  
CIN : U45203CT1981SG001853, PAN : AABCM6288N, GST Regn No22AABCM6288NSZY, Phone : 0771-6621000 Fax : 0771-2583794  
Website : www.csidc.in, Email address:csidc.cg@gov.nic.in, csidc\_raipur@yahoo.com

**REQUEST FOR PROPOSAL (RFP)**  
(Through e-Procurement Portal Only)  
**CSIDC/Flat.Fac.RFP/03/2026**  
**Raipur, Dated 04/07/2026**  
Chhattisgarh State Industrial Development Corporation (CSIDC) a Government of Chhattisgarh Undertaking constituted under the Companies Act, 1956 engaged in Industrial Infrastructure Development & Other Related Activities in the State envisages to develop " **Flatted Factory**" at Bhilai, Chhattisgarh.  
"Request for Proposal" (RFP) is for planning designing, financing, construction, development, marketing, operation & maintenance of proposed " **DEVELOPMENT OF FLATTED FACTORY UNDER PUBLIC PRIVATE PARTNERSHIP (PPP) MODE IN DBFOT MODEL AT AGRICULTURE IMPLEMENT FACTORY BHILAI (CHHATTISGARH)**" on leasehold as is where is basis.  

| Land                          | Area of land (in Acre/SQM)                               | FAR/FSI Offered | Land use proposed |
|-------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|-----------------|-------------------|
| Agriculture Implement Factory | 4.51 Acres (approx.) (Leasehold on as is where is basis) | 3.00            | Commercial        |

The RFP document containing detailed terms & condition, scope of work and other details is available for download from the web portal (website) <https://eproc.cgstate.gov.in> and shall be submitted online only Amendment in tender, if any, will only be uploaded on the website and shall not be published in any newspaper.  
**NOTE:** The interested tenders for online submission of tender may contact CG e-Proc Helpdesk, Operated by Mjunction Services Limited, they may reach Helpdesk using 18004199140 (from 9 AM to 11 PM) (therein press 2 for CG e-Proc) or you can email them at Helpdesk [eproc@cgswan.gov.in](mailto:eproc@cgswan.gov.in).  
Tenderer may contact to Chief Engineer, CSIDC (Mob. No. +91 99264-80284) Udyog Bhawan in working hours on working days to clear their doubts if any before online submission of the tender.  
samvad 48356/2 Chief Engineer

**S. E. RAILWAY – TENDER**  
Tender Notice No. : e-Tender/2026/25, dated 03.07.2026, e-Tenders are invited by Divisional Railway Manager (Engg), S.E.Railway, Kharagpur-721301 for and on behalf of the President of India for the following works **before 15.00 hrs.** on the date mentioned against items and will be opened at 15.30 hrs. : **Sl. No. & Tender No.; Description of work; Tender Value; Earnest Money :** (1) **E-KGP-South-22-2026;** Supply and stacking of 22,422 Cum machine crushed track ballast conforming to RDSO specification (IRS-GE-1) at Bangriposi ballast depot under the jurisdiction of Assistant Divisional Engineer/Balasore; ₹ 4,90,72,740.88/-; ₹ 9,81,500/-, (2) **E-KGP-WEST-26-2026;** Supply, stacking and loading into any type of Railway wagons of hardstone machine crushed Track Ballast of 50 mm gauge for 15,000 cum in Ballast Depot at Dhalbhumgarh under the jurisdiction of Divisional Engineer/West/Kharagpur; ₹ 3,19,96,650.00; ₹ 6,39,900/-, (3) **E-KGP-WEST-27-2026;** Supply, stacking and loading into any type of Railway Wagons of hard stone machine crushed track ballast of 50 mm gauge for 12,595 cum in ballast depot at Midnapore Station Yard under the jurisdiction of Divisional Engineer/West/Kharagpur; ₹ 3,22,80,833.00; ₹ 6,45,200/-, (4) **E-KGP-East-43-2026;** Santragachi: Development of station Drainage system under the jurisdiction of Sr. Divisional Engineer / East / Kharagpur; ₹ 3,44,70,228.91; ₹ 6,89,400/-, **Tender Document Cost :** 0.00 for each. **Completion period of the work :** 06 Months for each. **Date of opening :** 28.07.2026 for sl. no. 1 to 3 and 30.07.2026 for sl. no. 4. **Bidding start Date :** From 14.07.2026 and upto 15.00 hrs, on 28.07.2026 for sl. no. 1 to 3 and From 16.07.2026 and upto 15.00 hrs, on 30.07.2026 for sl. no. 4. Interested Tenderers may visit website **www.ireps.gov.in** for full details/descriptions/specifications of the tenders and submit their bids online. In no case manual tenders for these works will be accepted. **N.B.** Prospective bidders may regularly visit **www.ireps.gov.in** to participate in all tenders. (PR-421)

**NORTHERN RAILWAY**  
**Corrigendum Notice**

| Tender No. 365135                                                                                                                            | Dated: 06.07.2026                             |                       |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|-----------------------|
| <b>Corrigendum Details</b><br>Corrigendum No 5                                                                                               | <b>Corrigendum Publish Date</b><br>06.07.2026 |                       |
| <b>Tender Details</b><br>Tender No 365135 (Open Tender)<br>Name of Work: Comprehensive Maintenance Contract of Vande Bharat Express Trainset | <b>Closing Date/Time</b> 15.07.2026, 15:00    |                       |
| <b>Item Modified NIT Header</b>                                                                                                              |                                               |                       |
| <b>Field Name</b>                                                                                                                            | <b>Existing Value</b>                         | <b>Modified Value</b> |
| <b>Tender Closing Date Time</b>                                                                                                              | 08.07.2026, 15:00                             | 15.07.2026, 15:00     |
| 2307/2026                                                                                                                                    |                                               |                       |
| <b>Serving Customers With A Smile</b>                                                                                                        |                                               |                       |

**JAMMU AND KASHMIR POLICE**  
**DISTRICT POLICE HEADQUARTERS JAMMU**  
0191-2561578 (O), 0191-254780 (F), email-[sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in](mailto:sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in)  
**LOOK OUT NOTICE**

SDPO Domana, Jammu vide communication No. SDD/2026/8457 dated 04.07.2026 has intimated that one un-known dead body was found/recovered from village Kheri near CRPF Camp Bantialab, Jammu, was immediately shifted to GMCH Jammu for identification. However, to ascertain the actual cause of death, Inquest proceedings U/S 194 BNSs, was initiated at PP Chfinore vide DDR No. 10 dated 04.07.2026 and enquiry thereof started.  
For identification of said dead body wide publicity is required to be published on daily newspapers for identification / Public in general, having any clue related to the dead body. If any missing report is lodged, kindly communicate the same on the below mentioned contact/Telephone numbers.  
**Description Roll:-**  

|        |                             |
|--------|-----------------------------|
| Age    | : 65-70 years (Approx.)     |
| Height | : 5'04"                     |
| Colour | : Brownish                  |
| Beard  | : White                     |
| Dress  | : Black trouser/white shirt |

**Contacts/Telephone Numbers:-**  

|                      |                                                                          |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1. DPO, Jammu        | : 0191-2547807, 0191-2561578                                             |
| 2. SSP Jammu Mail LD | : <a href="mailto:sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in">sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in</a> |
| 3. PCR Jammu         | : 0191-2542000                                                           |
| 4. SP Rural          | : 0191-2605949                                                           |
| 5. SDPO Domana       | : 0191-2604220                                                           |
| 6. P/S Domana        | : 0191-2604214                                                           |

**Sr. Superintendent of Police, Jammu**  
Dated:- .07.2026  
No. CRB/26/ DIP No: DIP/J-5112/26

## Over 300 children killed or injured in Sudan war in 6 months: UNICEF

**CAIRO:**More than 300 children have been killed or injured in the last six months in the war in Sudan, mostly from drone strikes, the UN children's agency said on Monday.

The Sudanese military and the paramilitary Rapid Support Forces have been fighting since April 2023.

The war is now concentrated in the Kordofan, Darfur and Blue Nile states, with drone warfare causing 60 per cent of casualties, according to UNICEF.

The UN, US, UK and others have expressed alarm about potential atrocities as the RSF and the military fight for control of the strategic city of el-Obeid in North Kordofan. In Geneva on Monday, the UN-backed Human Rights Council approved a measure, brought by five European countries, condemning the escalating violence by the RSF and its allies in and around el-Obeid.



# ‘India & EU working to finish legal scrubbing of FTA text in 15-20 days’

‘We are going to Brussels, Spain, Brussels and Finland, because we have already started marketing Indian products, goods and services’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India and the European Union (EU) are expected to complete the legal scrubbing of the free trade agreement text in the next 15-20 days, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said on Monday.

India and the 27-nation bloc announced in January the conclusion of negotiations for the trade pact.

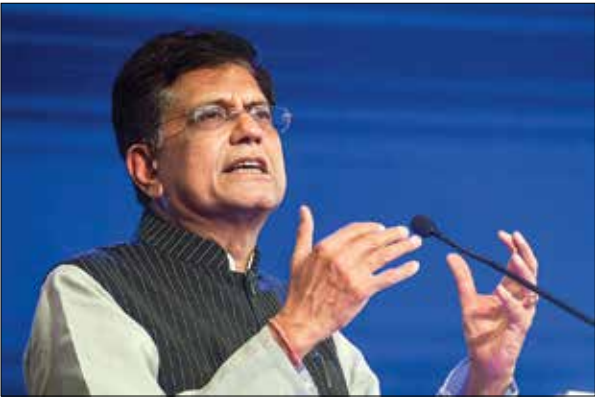
After the legal scrubbing of the text, both sides are expected to sign the agreement by the end of this year and may implement it next year.

“The EU at Brussels and we are working together to complete the legal scrubbing in the next 15-20 days,” he said here at an award event of the Council of Leather Exports (CLE).

Goyal said he will be in Brussels on July 14-15, along with a delegation of business persons.

“We are going to Brussels, Spain, Brussels and Finland, because we have already started marketing Indian products, goods and services,” he said.

“We have already started taking our business delegation, so that we are future-ready. We are ready to get the best out of the FTAs that we have final-



Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal

After the legal scrubbing of the text, both sides are expected to sign the agreement by the end of this year and may implement it next year

ised,” he added.

The minister has held discussions with Maros Sefcovic, the EU Trade Commissioner.

“We are meeting the President of the European Commission and the Council, our counterparts of Trade, Digital Technology, and Foreign Minister, for the Trade and Technology Council, TTC, meetings on the 14th and 15th of this month in Brussels,” Goyal said.

He added that India and the

EU are also discussing ways to speed up the legal scrub of the EU-India FTA, so that it can go in for ratification in their (EU’s) Commission and Parliament.

“And our effort is that in the first quarter of 2027, the EU-India FTA, which will open 27 developed countries for our businesses, which will be the mother of all these, will enter into force, will be operational, and take the country’s exports

Highlights

» Goyal said he will be in Brussels on July 14-15, along with a delegation of business persons

» ‘And our effort is that in the first quarter of 2027, the EU-India FTA, which will open 27 developed countries for our businesses, will enter into force’

» Further, Goyal said India is in dialogue with Canada for a trade pact and expressed hope that this could be concluded by the end of the year

to a newer height,” he said.

He pointed out that leather and leather product exports have reached \$4-4.5 billion, and the trade pacts will help create huge opportunities in developed countries.

“The new markets in developed nations that have been opened up for your sector. I think the time is right for all of you to aim big, aspire for much bigger achievements. The enabling conditions have been

created,” he said.

The minister asked the leather industry to aim for USD 15 billion in exports in the next 5-6 years.

“Finishing, designing, packaging, brand building. These are the areas which will define our future. Our export promotion mission is willing to extend every possible assistance that you may require,” he said.

Calling for diversification of export destinations, the minister said 77 per cent of India’s leather exports currently go to only 15 countries.

He said the time has come to diversify across the world.

Further, Goyal said India is in dialogue with Canada for a trade pact and expressed hope that this could be concluded by the end of the year.

In the Gulf Cooperation Council region, India already has FTAs with Oman and the UAE, and is negotiating with a six-country bloc, which could add four more countries, and take the number, under trade pacts, to 55.

India is also talking to Mexico, which would take the number to 56, and to Brazil and three other countries associated with it, taking the number to 60, he said.

# NSE targeting to launch its ₹30,000 crore IPO in Sept

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The National Stock Exchange (NSE) is targeting to launch its much-awaited initial public offering (IPO), estimated at around Rs 30,000 crore, in September, people familiar with the development said on Monday.

The mega IPO is expected to value the country’s largest stock exchange at over Rs 5 lakh crore.

The exchange will soon begin roadshows for the IPO.

If successful, the issue will surpass Hyundai Motor India’s Rs 27,870-crore public offering launched in October 2024.

The proposed public issue will be entirely an offer for sale (OFS) of 14.89 crore equity shares, with existing shareholders collectively divesting nearly 6 per cent of the exchange’s equity, according to the draft red herring prospectus (DRHP) filed in June. NSE has around 1.8 lakh shareholders.

Among the major shareholders selling their stake, State Bank of India will offload up to 2.48 crore shares, followed by MS Strategic (Mauritius) Ltd with 1.60 crore shares. Other shareholders proposing to sell shares include Canada Pension Plan Investment Board, Aranda Investments (Mauritius) Pte Ltd, Bank of Baroda, Stock Holding Corporation of India Ltd, General Insurance Corporation of India, The New India Assurance Company, National Insurance Company and United India Insurance Company. LIC, the exchange’s largest



‘The proposed IPO will be entirely an OFS of 14.89 crore shares, with existing shareholders collectively divesting nearly 6% of the exchange’s equity’

shareholder with a 10.72 per cent stake, will not participate in the share sale.

NSE’s board had approved the proposed IPO on February 6 following the receipt of the Securities and Exchange Board of India’s (Sebi) no-objection certificate (NOC).

NSE had first filed draft papers for its IPO in 2016 to raise around Rs 10,000 crore through an OFS. However, Sebi did not clear the proposal then amid concerns over governance issues and the co-location matter.

Since then, the exchange has undertaken several gover-

nance and compliance measures and made multiple representations to the regulator seeking approval. As part of the IPO process, NSE has appointed 20 merchant bankers, besides legal advisers and other intermediaries, to manage the public issue.

On the financial front, the exchange reported a 15 per cent decline in profit after tax to Rs 10,302 crore in FY26 from Rs 12,188 crore in FY25. Total income also eased to Rs 18,713 crore during the fiscal from Rs 19,177 crore a year earlier.

For the March quarter, however, profit after tax rose 8 per cent to Rs 2,871 crore from Rs 2,650 crore in the corresponding period of the previous financial year, while total income increased 22 per cent to Rs 5,360 crore from Rs 4,397 crore.

Close on the heels of the NSE announcement, Reliance Industries-promoted Jio Platforms also filed its draft papers with Sebi in June, and it is expected to be the largest public issue in the history of the Indian stock market.

# ‘India’s market valuation decline is temporary, economic growth recovery could boost equities’

NEW DELHI: India’s recent decline in market valuations is temporary rather than structural, and a recovery in economic growth could help reverse the trend and provide a boost to equities, according to a report by Morgan Stanley.

The report said that the combination of subdued recent market performance and lower foreign investor ownership could create a favourable environment for Indian equities going forward.

It stated, “India’s relative de-rating is cyclical and with growth acceleration in the pipeline, it has potential to reverse” Morgan Stanley argued that concerns suggesting India’s valuation decline is structural are overstated.

According to the report, one argument for a structural de-rating is that India’s long-term



growth could slow because of a declining fertility rate. Another concern is that artificial intelligence (AI) could hurt India’s services exports and trade.

However, the report said both concerns are exaggerated. It noted that while fertility rates are slowing, the change has not been abrupt and is likely to support economic growth over the next two decades, even though it may gradually reduce India’s long-term demographic advantage.

On artificial intelligence, the

report said AI could pose a near-term challenge to the country’s services export momentum. However, over the medium term, it also presents a significant opportunity to improve labour productivity from India’s relatively low productivity base.

Morgan Stanley further said India’s long-term growth outlook remains supported by several structural factors, including a multi-polar global economy that could increase India’s share in global goods trade, a growing consumer base and a significant pickup in investments.

The report therefore concluded that the decline in India’s market valuation is mainly cyclical and reflects the gap in relative economic growth compared with the rest of the world.

However, the report also shared that although India’s economic growth appears to have

bottomed out and is now moving higher, it still trails growth in some other economies, particularly those benefiting from the global artificial intelligence capital expenditure cycle.

Looking ahead, Morgan Stanley said the key trigger for Indian markets will be how investors assess the growth gap between India and the global economy. The report said market sentiment could improve if optimism around global AI-related capital expenditure moderates or if India’s economic growth accelerates further.

Morgan Stanley also expects the upcoming quarterly earnings season to provide important signals for investors and believes companies could deliver positive earnings surprises, supported by strong high-frequency economic indicators.

ANI

# Titan’s revenue jumps 41% in April-June qtr

NEW DELHI: Titan Co Ltd on Monday reported a 41 per cent growth in its revenue for the June quarter of FY27, driven by strong performances across its jewellery, watches and eye-wear segments.

This is the third successive quarter in which the Tata Group-managed firm has reported more than 40 per cent revenue growth.

In the December quarter of FY26, Titan had reported a 40 per cent growth in standalone revenue, which further accelerated to 46 per cent in the March quarter.

The leading branded jewellery and watch maker’s jewellery division reported 39 per cent growth in revenue in the April-June period of FY 2026-27. In FY26, the segment contributed around 91.5 per cent of the company’s over Rs 75,000 crore revenue.

Titan, which owns jewellery

Titan’s jewellery division posted 39% growth in revenue in April-June quarter of FY27

brands like Tanishq, Mia, Zoya, beYon and CaratLane, attributed this growth to a “robust festive and Akshaya Tritiya demand”, even as gold prices remained relatively stable, the company said in a regulatory filing.

Its buyer growth came in at early double digits amid relatively stable gold prices, while average ticket sizes rose in high double digits, the company said.

“Amidst (relatively) stable gold prices, the portfolio buyer growth came in early double-digits and the average ticket sizes grew in high double-digits. The core jewellery category

of plain and studded grew (individually) in the mid-thirties with coins continuing its investment-led strong double-digit growth momentum during this period,” Titan said in its quarterly business update.

Its watches division grew 23 per cent, with analogue watches – benefiting from continuing premiumisation trends – leading the growth in the high twenties.

However, “the smart watches business declined in the low teens,” it added. Titan’s EyeCare business also grew 23 per cent, supported by momentum across owned and international brands, calibrated marketing investments and a push towards multi-pair and multi-category purchases, the filing said.

Among emerging businesses, which grew overall 19 per cent, fragrances rose in the mid-teens, women’s bags recorded a strong double-digit

growth, while the ethnic wear brand Taneira grew in low single digits, it added.

“In the portfolio, Fragrances grew in mid-teens, Women’s Bags clocked strong double-digit growth for the quarter, and Taneira growth was in low single-digits,” it said.

While its International business, which mainly consists of jewellery brands, grew more than twofold to 128 per cent.

“The jewellery business of Tanishq, Mia, and CaratLane (combined) saw strong traction in North America and clocked encouraging double-digit growth in GCC. The volatile geopolitical situation notwithstanding, the core Damas business is witnessing a gradual recovery across key parameters,” the company said.

Titan is a joint venture between the Tata Group and the Tamil Nadu Industrial Development Corporation (TIDCO). PTI

# Govt to sell 5% stake in Cochin Shipyard at ₹1,400/share via OFS

The OFS opens for retail investors on July 8, 2026

NEW DELHI: The government will sell up to 5 per cent stake in Cochin Shipyard at a floor price of Rs 1,400 per share through an offer for sale beginning on Tuesday.

The “government announces offer for sale in Cochin Shipyard Ltd (CSL) with a base offer of 2.52 per cent of its paid-up equity and an additional 2.52 per cent as the green-shoe option in case of over subscription,” Department of Investment and Public Asset Management (DIPAM) Secretary Arunish Chawla said on X.

The offer for sale (OFS)



opens for non-retail investors on July 7, 2026. Retail investors can bid on July 8, 2026.

The floor price of Rs 1,400 per share is at a 7 per cent discount over Monday’s closing price on BSE.

Shares of Cochin Shipyard closed at Rs 1,504.75, down 1.25

per cent over the previous close on BSE on Monday.

The government currently holds a 67.91 per cent stake in Cochin Shipyard Ltd.

So far in the current fiscal, the government has sold stake via offer for sale in six public sector entities — Central Bank of India, Coal India, NHPC, NLC India, GIC and IRFC, garnering a cumulative Rs 18,561 crore.

For the full fiscal year, the government has budgeted to raise Rs 80,000 crore via PSU disinvestment and asset monetisation.

PTI

# AERA unlikely to extend 25% waiver in landing & parking charges for airlines at major airports

The sources on Monday said that airport operators have not received any extension order regarding the reduced landing and parking charges

NEW DELHI: Airports tariff regulator AERA is unlikely to extend the 25 per cent waiver in landing and parking charges for domestic flights across major airports, according to sources.

The Airports Economic Regulatory Authority (AERA), on the civil aviation ministry’s directive on April 7, announced a three-month waiver for all domestic flights in the wake of the West Asia turmoil posing financial challenges for the airlines.

The sources on Monday



said that airport operators have not received any extension order regarding the reduced

landing and parking charges, and, per se, the waiver has lapsed. There was no immediate

response from the civil aviation ministry on the issue.

“Landing and parking charges (part of aeronautical tariff) at all major airports shall be reduced by 25 per cent from the prevailing tariff. This reduction shall take effect immediately and will be applicable on all domestic flights for a period of three months,” AERA had said in its order dated April 7.

“After due consideration, the authority has decided to implement the directions issued by the government,” it had said.

PTI

# Trent’s Q1 revenue up 19% to ₹5,666 crore

NEW DELHI: Tata group’s retail firm Trent Ltd’s standalone revenue for the June quarter has risen by 19 per cent to Rs 5,666 crore, according to a quarterly update by the company.

Trent’s standalone revenue for the corresponding June quarter a year ago was at Rs 4,781 crore, according to the update filed on Monday.

The company operates retail stores under the brand names such as Westside, Zudio and Star.

“Revenue from sale of merchandise (excl. other operating income) also grew by 19 per cent during the quarter ended June 2026,” said Trent.

During the quarter, Trent opened 1 Westside and 19 of its value offering format Zudio, which targets the affordable fast fashion segment.

Besides, Trent also has the grocery business Star. “As of 30th June 2026, our portfolio of 1,312 stores includes 301 Westside, 982 Zudio (including 7 in the UAE) and 29 stores across other lifestyle concepts,” it said.

Shares of Trent Ltd on Monday settled at Rs 3,343.40 on BSE, up 0.08 per cent.

PTI

# NIM recovery still elusive for banks in Q1 despite easing funding costs: Analysts

While banks have begun repricing deposits, funding costs remain relatively high & are likely to keep margins range-bound in Q1 FY27

MUMBAI: Banks are likely to report largely stable to lower net interest margins (NIMs) in the June quarter as the benefits of deposit repricing only partly offset pressure from lower-yielding corporate loans and elevated bulk deposit costs, according to brokerage reports.

Brokerages said the impact of the earlier repo rate cuts has largely played out, with external benchmark-linked loans absorbing most of the transmission. While banks have begun repricing deposits, funding costs remain relatively high and are expected to keep margins range-bound in the first quarter of FY27.

Motilal Oswal said state-owned lenders’ margins are likely to remain broadly stable in a narrow range, while private banks are expected to report a mixed performance, with HDFC Bank, ICICI Bank and Axis Bank likely to post a marginal decline in net interest margins versus the March quarter, even as some mid-sized lenders may see modest expansion.

Systematix Research also expects NIMs across its coverage universe to remain broadly stable or witness marginal sequential compression, while Dolat Capital estimates around

CLOSER LOOK

» Motilal Oswal said state-owned lenders’ margins are likely to remain broadly stable in narrow range, while pvt banks are expected to report a mixed performance

» HDFC Bank, ICICI Bank and Axis Bank likely to post a marginal decline in NIMs, the brokerage said

» Deposit mobilisation continues to remain a challenge for lenders as loan growth outpaces deposit accretion

a 0.05 per cent decline for its banking coverage.

Analysts said expected inflows into Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) or FCNR(B) deposits could provide some relief to funding con-

ditions in the coming quarters.

According to Dolat Capital, bankers are expecting around \$50 billion of FCNR(B) inflows, equivalent to about 1.8 per cent of deposits, by August under the scheme valid till Septem-

ber, with the benefits likely to become visible from the second quarter. Motilal Oswal also said the FCNR route should provide some relief and help deposit mobilisation till September 2026.

Despite the pressure on margins, banks are expected to deliver healthy earnings growth in the June quarter, supported by robust loan growth and lower provisioning costs, analysts said.

Brokerages expect banks to deliver profit growth in the range of 9-14 per cent year-on-year. However, some expect profit may fall on a quarterly basis. It can be noted that the

banks’ NIMs have been under pressure over the last few quarters, especially after the RBI turned to cutting interest rates in 2025 as inflation conditions eased. The pressure on NIMs impacts the core income of banks.

Deposit mobilisation, however, continues to remain a challenge for lenders as loan growth outpaces deposit accretion.

Banking system credit expanded 17.7 per cent year-on-year as of June 15, 2026, while deposit growth stood at 12 per cent, pushing the system credit-deposit ratio to around 83.4 per cent. Analysts said competi-

tion for retail deposits remains intense, forcing banks to rely more on wholesale deposits even as term deposit rates stay relatively sticky.

In the provisional numbers, the pressure on the low-cost deposits of state-owned banks was visible with Union Bank’s CASA ratio declining marginally to 35.10 per cent from 35.51 per cent a year ago, while Central Bank of India’s CASA ratio fell to 46.61 per cent from 46.88 per cent.

Indian Bank’s domestic CASA ratio also eased to 39.64 per cent from 39.67 per cent at the end of March.

PTI



# Automobile retail sales up 21.83% to 25,57,234 units in June: FADA

In June last year total automobile retail sales in India stood at 20,98,996 units, Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations (FADA) said

## OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Total automobile retail sales in India grew by 21.83 per cent year-on-year to 25,57,234 units in June, with the industry remaining cautiously optimistic going forward hoping for monsoon to make up for the deficit, Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations (FADA) said on Monday.

In June last year total automobile retail sales in India stood at 20,98,996 units, FADA said in a statement.

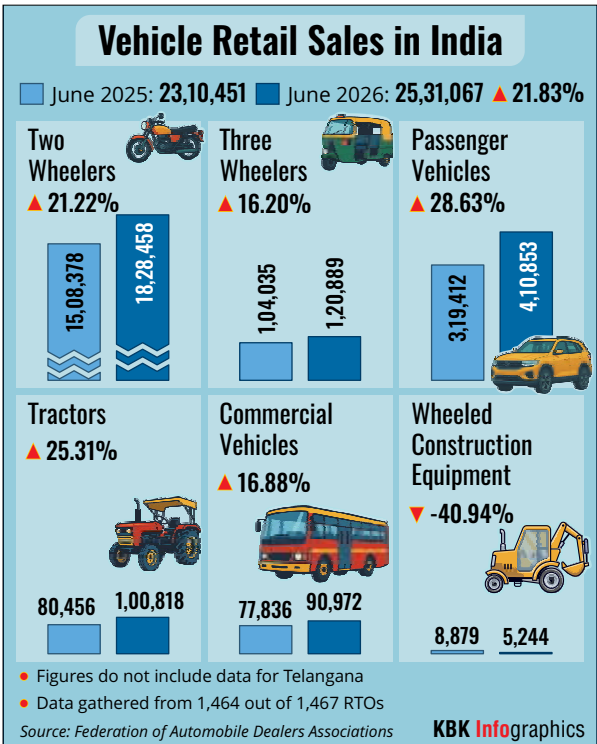
Passenger vehicles (PV) retail sales were at 4,10,853 units last month as compared to 3,19,412 units in June 2025, a growth of 28.63 per cent, it added.

Two-wheelers sales were at 18,28,458 units in June this year as compared to 15,08,378 units in the same month a year ago, at a growth of 21.22 per cent, it added.

FADA further said three-wheeler sales stood at 1,20,889 units last month as compared to 1,04,035 units in June 2025, up 16.20 per cent.

Commercial vehicles also witnessed a growth of 16.88 per cent at 90,972 units last month as compared to 77,836 units in June 2025, it added.

Commenting on the performance, FADA President C



S Vigneshwar said, "June 2026 has been a landmark month for Indian auto retail, the best June ever recorded, with two-wheelers, three-wheelers, commercial vehicles, passenger vehicles and overall registrations each posting their highest-ever June figures."

On the near-term outlook for the ongoing month,

FADA said, dealer sentiment stays constructive, with 51.24 per cent of dealers expecting growth, 41.79 per cent anticipating a flat market and only 6.97 per cent foreseeing a decline.

"Expectations rest on the monsoon making up its deficit, Kharif sowing gathering pace and supplies staying nor-

## Highlights

» Passenger vehicles (PV) retail sales were at 4,10,853 units last month against 3,19,412 units in June 2025, a growth of 28.63%

» Commercial vehicles sales grew 16.88% to 90,972 units last month against 77,836 units in June 2025

» Two-wheelers sales were at 18,28,458 units in June against 15,08,378 units in June 2025, up by 21.22%

» Three-wheeler sales stood at 1,20,889 units last month as compared to 1,04,035 units in June 2025, up 16.20 per cent

ment entered July with healthy booking pipelines, particularly in EVs and CNG, and fresh launches, while commercial vehicles should stay steady on freight and infrastructure-linked activity, FADA said.

In two-wheelers, improving rural cashflows, once rainfall catches up and the accelerating shift towards EV and fuel-efficient models should provide support, though deficient-rainfall pockets and the July OEM price hikes may keep some buyers in wait-and-watch mode, it added.

For the July-September 2026 period, FADA said dealer confidence strengthens markedly, "with 66.17 per cent expecting growth, the firmest medium-term reading in recent surveys, while only 3.98 per cent expect de-growth".

Notably, it added, "38.31 per cent of dealers have revised their FY27 retail outlook upward against just 16.42 per cent downward, signalling conviction that the record-setting first quarter of FY27 (a positive 15.35 per cent YoY growth) can carry into the festive season".

However, it said dealers identify a monsoon short-fall/El Nino impact on rural demand as the single biggest risk, followed by further price hikes affecting affordability and inventory pile-up pressure.

malised following the West Asia ceasefire and easing crude prices," the automotive dealers' body said.

Overall, it said, "The outlook for July 2026 appears cautiously optimistic with monsoon catch-up and rural cashflows the key swing factors ahead of the festive season."

The passenger vehicles seg-

# Markets settle at over two-month high on gains in bank, oil stocks

Rupee depreciates by 25 paise to 95.43 against US dollar

## OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: Stock markets extended the gaining streak to the fourth day on Monday, with the benchmark Sensex rising by 521 points to settle at a more-than-two-month high, driven by buying in blue-chip bank and oil shares and lower crude oil prices.

The 30-share BSE Sensex jumped 521.16 points, or 0.67 per cent, to settle at 78,285.07, a closing level not seen since April 22. During the day, it surged 634.15 points, or 0.81 per cent, to 78,398.06.

The 50-share NSE Nifty climbed 159.50 points, or 0.66 per cent, to end at 24,430.35, the highest closing level since April 21.

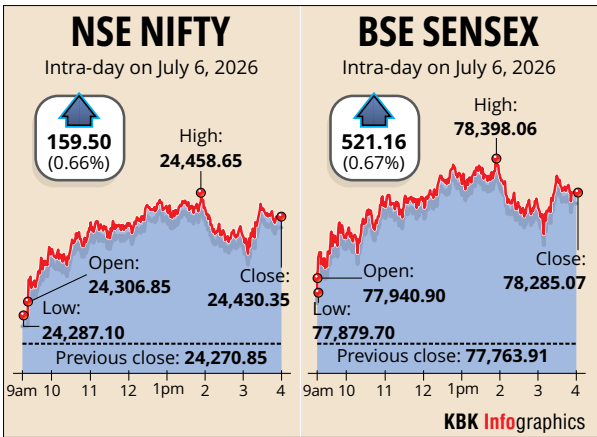
In four consecutive trading days, the BSE benchmark has jumped 1,806.4 points, or 2.36% & the Nifty by 564.6 points, or 2.36%

Fresh foreign fund inflows aided the optimistic trend in the domestic equity market, analysts said. Foreign institutional investors bought equities worth Rs 1,355.33 crore on Friday, according to exchange data.

Among the Sensex pack, HDFC Bank climbed the most by 3.59 per cent. Mahindra & Mahindra, Bharat Electronics, Reliance Industries, ICICI Bank, and Maruti were also among the winners.

Kotak Mahindra Bank, Tata Consultancy Services, Bajaj Finserv, and Power Grid were among the laggards.

Brent crude, the global oil



In four consecutive trading days, the BSE benchmark has jumped 1,806.4 points, or 2.36% & the Nifty by 564.6 points, or 2.36%

benchmark, declined 0.82 per cent to \$71.53 per barrel.

"Indian equities traded with a positive bias despite mixed global cues, supported by stable crude prices. Continued softness in crude would support inflation, the current account balance, OMC profitability, and overall macro stability," Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Ltd, said.

Broader markets also advanced as the BSE MidCap Select index climbed 0.71 per cent and SmallCap Select index went up by 0.47 per cent.

Sectorally, Realty jumped the most by 1.82 per cent, followed by MidSmall Private Banks Quality Tilt (1.40 per cent), Private Banks index (1.50 per cent), Top 10 Banks (1.24 per cent), Capital Goods (1.19 per cent) and Auto (1.14 per cent).

IT, Utilities, PSU Bank, Focused IT and Services were the laggards.

The rupee depreciated 25 paise to close at 95.43 against the US dollar on Monday, as a strengthening greenback weighed on emerging market currencies.

In Asian markets, Hong Kong's Hang Seng settled higher, while South Korea's Kospi and Japan's Nikkei 225 and Shanghai's SSE Composite index ended lower.

Markets in Europe were trading on a mixed note.

US markets were closed on Friday due to the country's Independence Day celebrations.

## CORPORATE KALEIDOSCOPE



Power Grid Corporation of India Limited (POWERGRID) has secured a landmark green loan of JPY 80 billion from Japan Bank for International Cooperation (JBIC), marking a significant milestone in advancing India's renewable energy transition. The loan agreement was signed between POWERGRID and JBIC on June 17, 2026. The financing facility has been extended to support the Khavda-Nagpur High Voltage Direct Current (HVDC) transmission project.

# Govt relaxes verification norms for high capacity weighing instruments

NEW DELHI: The government has eased the compliance requirements for standard weight verification carried out for weighing instruments having at least one tonne capacity, a move that will improve the ease of doing business for industries, warehouses, logistics operators and weighbridge owners.

The Department of Consumer Affairs has issued the amended Legal Metrology (General) Rules, 2011.

An official release on Monday said the norms have been revised to substantially reduce the requirement of standard weights for verification of high-

capacity weighing instruments by introducing a scientific, repeatability-based verification approach.

While verifying weighing instruments having a maximum capacity of one tonne and above, standard weights of at least one tonne or 50 per cent of the maximum capacity of the instrument, whichever was greater, had to be used before substitution with constant loads.

Since these provisions often resulted in significant logistical challenges, transportation costs and operational difficulties for industries and weighbridge operators, the changes

have been made, according to the consumer affairs ministry. "Under the revised provisions, the requirement has been rationalised."

"Based on the successful conduct of the repeatability test, the mandatory quantity of standard weights required before substitution with constant loads has been reduced from 50 per cent of the maximum capacity to only one-fifth (20 per cent) of the maximum capacity, while maintaining the prescribed standards of verification accuracy and reliability," the ministry said in the release.

**BHUBANESWAR:** Eminent educationist and social reformer, and Founder of KIIT, KIMS and KISS, Dr. Achyuta Samanta, has been conferred the AAPI Award for Transformational Social Work & Indo-US Partnership by the American Association of Physicians of Indian Origin (AAPI) at its annual convention, AAPI-CON 2026, held in Tampa, Florida, USA.

The award was presented during AAPICON 2026 and AAPI's 44th Congress, held from July 2 to 5, in recognition of Dr. Samanta's outstanding social service, visionary philanthropy, transformational humanitarian initiatives, exemplary support to AAPI during the Global Health Summit 2026, and his significant contribution towards strengthening Indo-US partnership.

The award was presented to Dr. Samanta by Dr. Amit Chakrabarty, President, AAPI in the presence of 3,000 physicians.

The association also lauded Dr. Samanta for his lifelong dedication to social service and his unwavering commit-



ment to uplifting the underprivileged through education, healthcare and humanitarian initiatives.

AAPI is one of the oldest and largest organisations of physicians of Indian origin in the US, representing more than 120,000 Indian-origin doctors. Its members serve communities across the US, and more than 3,000 physicians attended this year's convention.

On July 4, coinciding with US Independence Day, Dr. Samanta was invited as the Guest of Honour and keynote speaker at a special session of the convention. In his address,

he praised AAPI's outstanding contribution to healthcare and community service while highlighting the importance of stronger collaboration between India and the Indian diaspora in advancing global health.

Dr. Samanta also appealed to AAPI physicians to dedicate a few days every month to providing healthcare services in India. Responding positively to his appeal, AAPI expressed its support and assured that its member doctors would endeavour to spend 7 to 15 days every month offering medical consultation and healthcare services in India.

# BoM's credit growth rises 27% to ₹3.06 lakh cr in Q1 FY27

NEW DELHI: Bank of Maharashtra (BoM) on Monday said it has recorded a 27 per cent year-on-year increase in its total credit to Rs 3.06 lakh crore in the first quarter.

The Pune-based public sector lender's outstanding credit stood at Rs 2.41 lakh crore at the end of the April-June quarter of FY26, BoM said in a reg-

ulatory filing.

The total credit included loans to the retail, agriculture and MSME (RAM) segments, which grew 25 per cent year-on-year to Rs 1.87 lakh crore, it said.

During the quarter, the bank's exposure to corporate credit also crossed Rs 1 lakh crore to Rs 1.11 lakh crore, reg-



istering an increase of 21 per cent.

The lender reported a 13 per cent rise in total deposits to Rs 3.44 lakh crore in the reporting quarter against Rs 3.05 lakh crore at the end of the first quarter of the previous financial year.

As a result, the total business (total credit and deposits) of the bank registered an increase of 19 per cent to Rs

6.51 lakh crore compared with Rs 5.46 lakh crore at the end of June 30, 2025.

During the latest quarter, it said, the Current Accounts and Savings Accounts (CASA) ratio stood at 49 per cent of the total deposits against 50 per cent in the same period of the preceding financial year.

# Vande Bharat, Metro & sports university: Jupiter Wagons' ML Lohia charts next journey

As Jupiter Wagons gears up to make Vande Bharat & Metro coaches in Bengal, Lohia says India will emerge as the world's leading OEM supplier in 5 years

## ANINDITA ACHARYA

In 2006, Murari Lal Lohia founded Jupiter Wagons along with his US-retained son, Vivek Lohia. Two decades later, Jupiter Wagons has emerged as one of India's leading railway wagon manufacturers, with the octogenarian entrepreneur now among Kolkata's wealthiest businessmen. From manufacturing railway wagons, wheelsets and braking systems, the company has steadily diversified into commercial vehicles through Jupiter Electric Mobility (JEM). It is now preparing for its next big leap, manufacturing Metro and Vande Bharat coaches in West Bengal. Lohia said the new manufacturing facility is expected to be ready within the next 15 months in Hooghly district.

Today, Jupiter Wagons operates nine plants in Bengal, Jamshedpur, Indore, Jabalpur and Himachal Pradesh. Born in Rajasthan, Lohia moved to Kolkata at the age of three and the city has remained both his home and the centre of his professional journey ever since. The veteran industrialist is also a passionate patron of sports and

culture. As president of East Bengal, one of Bengal's most iconic football clubs, he dreams of establishing a sports university in the state and nurturing more local sporting talent.

We met the octogenarian businessman at his Taratala office on a rainy afternoon in Kolkata. He fondly recalls negotiating a deal with the legendary Ratan Tata as a 22-year-old, speaks about why he still makes it a point to visit factory workshops and shares his happiness that his grandson has begun training to join the family business. Lohia also speaks with conviction about India's future and said the country will become the global leader in supplying Original Equipment Manufacturer (OEM) products within the next five years. From business and manufacturing to sports and culture, the business maestro speaks candidly with the *Millennium Post*.

When Jupiter Wagons entered the railway sector in 2006, a handful of established players dominated the market. What did you believe they were missing that gave Jupiter an opportunity to grow so rapidly?

Yes, Texmaco and Titagarh were already there when we entered the market. But I have always believed in introducing new products. Today, we have nine plants, including two in Bengal—one at Bandel and another at Taratala. My philosophy in life is to keep moving forward. Every year, I introduced a new product. From wagon manufacturing, we expanded into braking systems, containers, passenger coaches and electric commercial vehicles. Diversification is the key to any business.

I have already planned five new products for the next five years. As a businessman, you should always have a backup plan. Within the next 15 months, we will set up a new plant in Hooghly district dedicated to manufacturing Vande Bharat and Metro coaches. The exact location will be disclosed later. We are also interested in manufacturing tram cars and tracks... we have done that before. With the new Bengal government interested to revive trams, we are hopeful. In addition, we are setting up an integrated axle and wheel manufacturing unit in Odisha in collaboration with a Ger-



Murari Lal Lohia founded Jupiter Wagons

man partner, with an investment of Rs 3,000 crore. The plant is expected to become operational by December 2027. We also have major plans to establish a sports university in Bengal.

Before becoming an entrepreneur, you spent years building businesses for others. What was the defining moment when you decided it was time to build something of your own?

I have two sons. Both were studying in the USA while I was in service. I always felt they should not work for someone else. After they completed their education, I asked them to return to India. Ini-

**"I PLAN TO APPROACH WEST BENGAL GOVT FOR 35 ACRES OF LAND TO SET UP SPORTS UNIVERSITY, WITH AN ESTIMATED INVESTMENT OF NEARLY ₹300 CRORE"**

tially, they questioned why they should come back when the USA offered far more opportunities. But India has always been my priority. I told them we would build our own business in our own country. In 2006, I founded Jupiter Wagons along with my son Vivek.

Did you always want to become a businessman?

My father used to produce cotton in Gujarat and sell it in Kolkata. He was never short of money. I learnt an important lesson in business from him... if you don't have money, nobody comes to you. If I have money, I can serve the local population. But money alone is not enough. You also need knowl-

edge. That is why I studied hard and got into IIT Kharagpur. Later, I went to the USA for my MBA and received training at General Motors. After returning to Kolkata, I joined Hindustan Development Corporation (HDC). That was the only job I ever did. In 2006, Jupiter Wagons was founded.

You and your sons run the company together. How did the two generations complement each other in building the business? Were there moments when your approaches differed significantly?

There have been moments of agreement and disagreement. That's only natural. I often think about whether the third generation will remain interested in the business. I have seen this happen in many family-run businesses. Till the second generation, there is strong involvement. But the third generation is often less interested in talking to workers or visiting workshops. They inherit easy money and prefer investing in shares.

I am happy that both my sons and now my grandson, who is 20 and currently undergoing training under me, are

involved. The officers and engineers in my company have also stayed with me for the last 20 to 25 years. It is loyalty that makes the difference. All our nine plants are doing well.

Your acquisitions of Stone India and Bonatrans India have significantly expanded the company's scale and capabilities. You have also partnered with global companies such as Tatravagonka. How important have these collaborations been in taking Jupiter global?

Setting up an industry in Europe is not easy. I convinced my partners there to invest in India. Today, we operate in five countries, including Slovakia, France, the Czech Republic, Italy and Germany. Over the next five years, we plan to expand into more parts of Europe.

India is pushing 'Make in India' and investing heavily in rail infrastructure. Do you believe India can become a global engineering powerhouse?

India will become the leader in supplying Original Equipment Manufacturer (OEM)

products within the next five years. Whether it is defence, railways or any other sector, India will lead. Artificial Intelligence (AI) is also transforming every industry, and the railway sector will benefit immensely from it.

You must have been delighted after East Bengal won their first-ever ISL title and their first national league title in 22 years.

I have always been passionate about sports. I am not a president who believes that simply giving money to the club is enough. I want players from Bengal and across India to represent East Bengal. I want to see more grassroots and local talent coming through the system. That is why we want to build a sports university in Bengal to nurture homegrown sporting talent. I plan to approach the West Bengal government for around 35 acres of land to set up the sports university. The project will involve an investment of nearly Rs 300 crore. I am also interested in culture, which is why I became associated with Anamika Kala Sangam and Padatik in Kolkata. Today, sports and culture give me immense satisfaction.

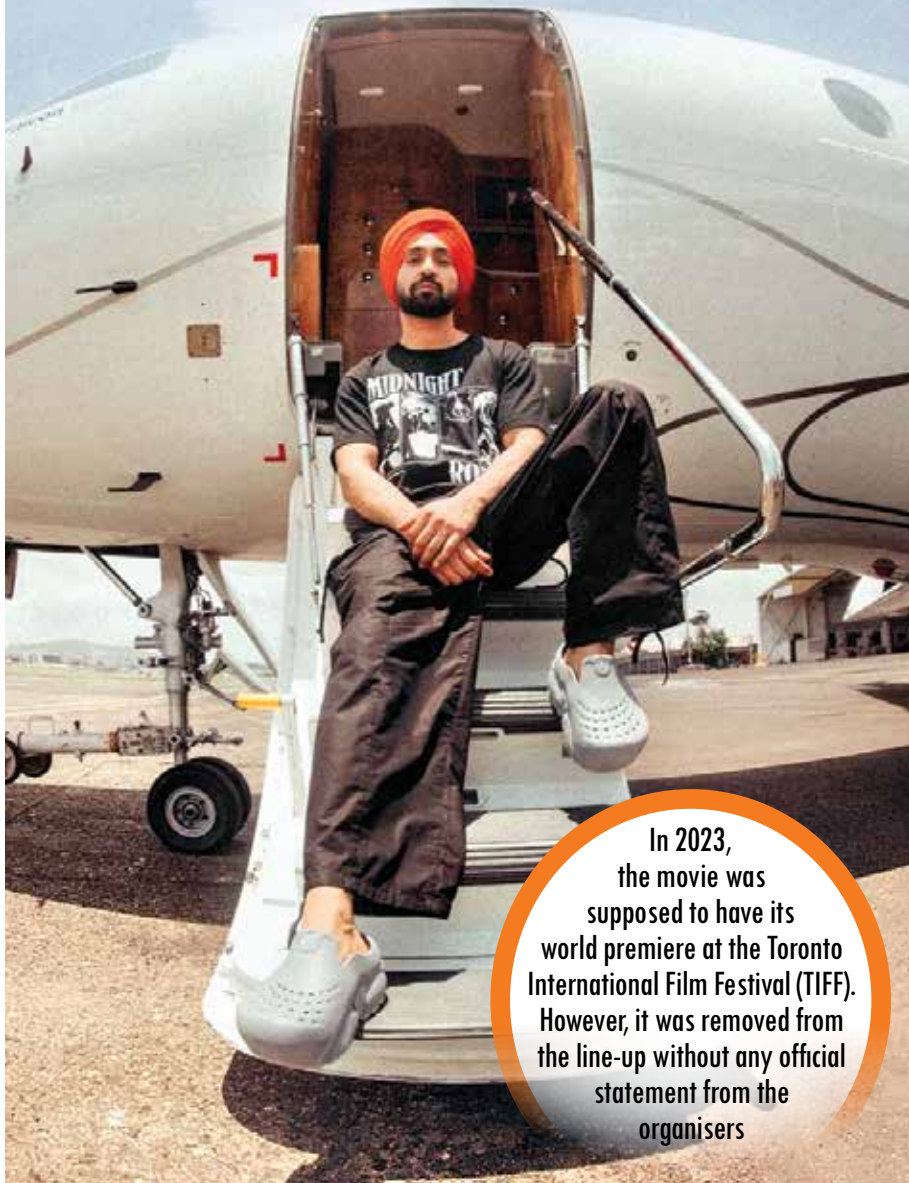






# DILJIT DOSANJH'S 'NOT SHOCKED' AFTER 'SATLUJ' REMOVED FROM OTT

The sudden removal of the film from OTT has triggered both creative and political controversies



In 2023, the movie was supposed to have its world premiere at the Toronto International Film Festival (TIFF). However, it was removed from the line-up without any official statement from the organisers



OUR CORRESPONDENT

Just two days ago, actor-musician Diljit Dosanjh's long-delayed film 'Satluj' started streaming on 'Zee5' on July 3. On Sunday, the Jaswant Singh Khalsa biopic, directed by Honey Trehan, was taken down from the streaming platform. The film, which is based on the 1990s Punjab insurgency era, was released on OTT after being delayed for more than three years due to a CBFC certification issue. This sudden removal of the film from OTT has triggered both creative and political controversies.

While several distinguished personalities like Harbhajan Singh, Onir and Ranvir Shorey have expressed their disappointment over the film's removal, Shiromani Akali Dal's chief Sukhbir Singh Badal condemned the move. "Punjab deserves to confront its past with honesty, not suppression," he said. Kulwant Singh Mannan, the chief secretary of the Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee (SGPC), appealed to the people of Punjab to watch 'Satluj'. Ex-India cricketer Harbhajan wrote, "Punjab's mothers are still waiting for answers. Truth cannot remain buried forever."

In his first reaction, Diljit, who is presently in the US for a music tour, shared a cryptic post on 'Instagram'. He posted a still from the movie with a hard-hitting caption. "I challenge the darkness," he wrote. In fact, the acclaimed actor-musician said he isn't surprised that the film has been banned. "I had a feeling on Friday that something like this would happen. This was already on my mind. It is not something to be shocked about (the ban)," he said in an Insta-

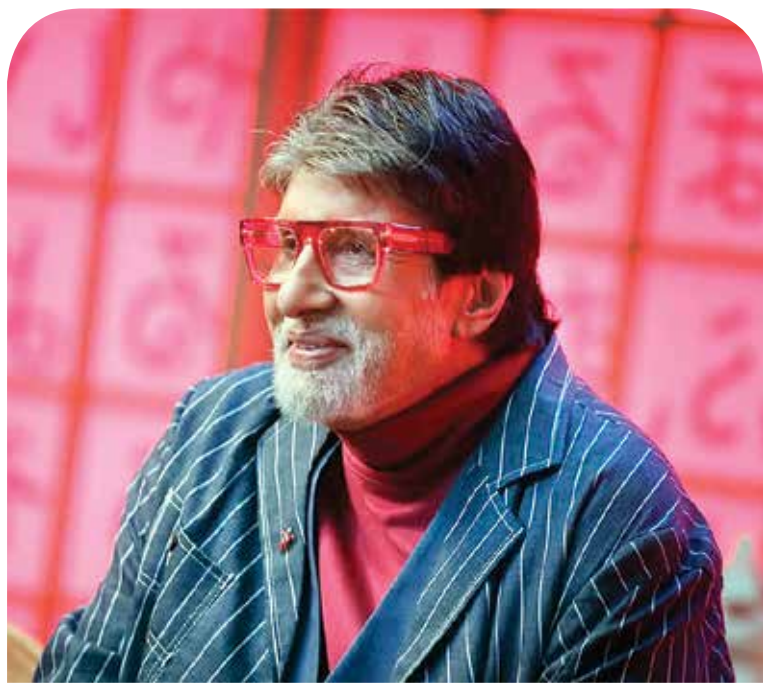
gram live from the US.

Diljit also spoke about how the film was being screened at a gurdwara in Rajasthan. "The youth today is talking about the film. I am satisfied that the film has reached you," he said. The 'Amar Singh Chamkila' actor said that the more one tries to stop the film, the more it would become a talking point. "Nothing disappears from the internet, not even a voice note on 'WhatsApp,'" he said.

Meanwhile, 'Zee5' issued a statement after the removal of the film. "In light of the current developments, 'Satluj' will be unavailable in India until further notice. We remain committed to exploring every appropriate avenue through due process to bring the film back to our audiences at the earliest opportunity," the official statement read.

In another development, advocate Vineet Jindal has filed a complaint with the Ministry of Home Affairs and urged the government to file an FIR against the director, actor and the streaming platform for spreading misinformation and sympathising with terrorism.

The film, originally titled 'Punjab '95', was stuck with the censors for more than three years. The director and actor refused to release it with the 127 cuts suggested by the Central Board of Film Certification. The film unveils one of the darkest chapters of Punjab's militant era. Diljit is seen playing Jaswant Singh Khalsa, a Sikh human rights activist who documented the alleged illegal disappearances and secret cremations of Sikhs in the 1990s. The film also stars Arjun Rampal, Kanwaljit Singh, Suvinder Vicky and Geetika Vidya Ohlyan in key roles.



## 'My respect as always'

Bollywood megastar Amitabh Bachchan expressed gratitude to his fans

NEW DELHI: 'It is deeply moving for me', said Bollywood megastar Amitabh Bachchan as he expressed gratitude to his fans, who gathered around his Jalsa house despite heavy rains in Mumbai to catch a glimpse of the actor.

Bachchan, who has been in the industry for over five decades, comes out of his residence every Sunday to meet his fans, who gather around his house. The actor has been following his Sunday ritual for years.

The 'Sholay' actor shared pictures of the meet-and-greet on his personal blog on Monday and said his fans come despite the harsh weather, be it during the rains or in winter and wait for him. Mumbai is currently facing severe

monsoon conditions.

The pictures featured the actor wearing a white kurta-pyjama and a waistcoat, greeting his fans. "A wave, folded palms... A signing of autographs and they endure and leave. My respect as always..." They come despite the weather

- rain, shine, winter and the same enthusiasm... So deeply moving for me," he wrote.

The actor is active on social media and often shares posts for his fans, to whom he also refers as EF, which stands for 'Extended Family'.

Bachchan will next feature in the sequel to 'Kalki 2898 AD' and 'Section 84', where he will appear alongside Diana Penty and Nimrat Kaur.

The 'Sholay' actor shared pictures of the meet-and-greet on his personal blog



## 'Thought Christopher didn't like my performance in The Odyssey'

LOS ANGELES: Hollywood star Tom Holland said he assumed Oscar-winning filmmaker Christopher Nolan didn't like his performance on the sets of 'The Odyssey'. The film is directed by Nolan and is set to release in theatres on July 17. It also features Matt Damon, Zendaya, Robert Pattinson, Lupita Nyong'o, Anne Hathaway, Charlize Theron and others.

The 'Spider-Man' actor said he was working with IMAX cameras for the first time and didn't understand why the director would cut his shot every three minutes.

"I thought I was totally s\*\*\*\*\*g the bed during his first day on set with the director, who had to cut every three minutes due to the IMAX technology... Working with the IMAX cameras for the first time is an experience. It is unlike anything I have ever seen before and I didn't know that it only ran for three minutes. So, I remember you would continue cutting and I was with Jon Bernthal like, 'Why does he keep cutting? Why does he keep doing that?'" the actor told 'Fandango' in an interview.

He added, "And in my head, I was like, 'Does he not like what we're doing? What is happening?' And then, I remember it was actually (stunt coordinator) George Cottle that was like, 'No, no, no, no, no.' There are only three minutes in the mag," he said.



## Raveena calls trolling of Aishwarya Rai Bachchan 'incredibly unfair'

MUMBAI: Raveena Tandon criticised the online trolling of actor Aishwarya Rai Bachchan at an international red-carpet event and called it 'deeply unfortunate and incredibly unfair'.

Aishwarya in May this year drew widespread attention for her annual appearance at the Cannes Film Festival, where she walked the red carpet in a sculpted blue gown by Amit Aggarwal. She later became the subject of online trolling after photographs and videos from the festival were shared on social media.

Raveena said the constant scrutiny of women's looks reflects a 'toxic trait' in the social media age.

"It is unfortunate and incredibly unfair. This relentless, hyper-fixation on a woman's ageing process, her weight or her wardrobe choice is an ongoing toxic trait of our digital culture," the actress told PTL.

Raveena Tandon said the constant scrutiny of women's looks reflects a 'toxic trait' in the social media age

Describing Aishwarya as a 'global icon', Raveena said reducing the actor to such judgments undermines her contribution and stature.

"Aishwarya is an absolute global icon who has represented our country with unparalleled dignity and grace on international platforms for decades. To reduce a woman of her stature, achievements and intelligence down to a bad camera angle or an experimental dress is just miserable behaviour," she said.

The backlash reflects a broader cultural double standard in how male and female actors are perceived, she added. "It reveals a broader, everyday cultural double standard, like we demand our female stars remain permanently frozen in time, looking exactly like they did twenty years ago, while male actors are allowed to age, change and grow without an ounce of the same brutal scrutiny," the 53-year-old actress, who is basking in the success of her latest movie 'Welcome to the Jungle', said.

"It's high time people online log off, look inward and learn to respect women who are living their lives beautifully, maturely and entirely on their own terms," she said.

Besides Raveena, Madhuri Dixit Nene and others came out in support of Aishwarya following online criticism surrounding her appearance at the festival.

# Hidden pillars of OTT: Actors who make a difference

Forget conventional heroes; these actors have become the backbone of India's popular Hindi web shows

KANZA WAJAHAT

Sitting down to watch 'Raakh', the latest crime thriller on 'Amazon Prime Video' inspired by the infamous 1978 Ranga-Billa case, was a deeply disturbing experience. Several moments during the binge-watch sent chills down our spine and much of that had to do with Akash Makhija's performance as 'Babu'. As the menacing antagonist, he portrays a character who isn't merely a villain created for the screen but someone who could very well exist in society. Makhija has already proved his mettle in projects like 'Gram Chikitsalay' and 'Bhool Chuk Maaf', but in 'Raakh', he creates such a disturbing world that his character refuses to leave your mind long after the credits roll. He may not have been the lead actor in the series, but his sheer performance elevates it to another level.

In fact, OTT platforms have given us several remarkable actors

like Makhija who, in mainstream Bollywood, might have been sidelined or never had the opportunity to showcase their talent fully. Simply because they don't fit the conventional 'hero' mould, they may not have been considered leading men. Yet, their talent surpasses such superficial standards. 'Millennium Post' lists some of the finest OTT actors who have proved their exceptional artistic range.



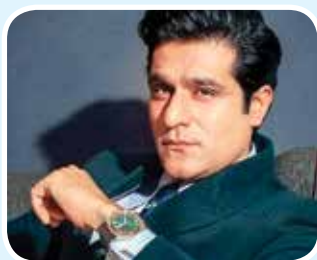
Ishwak Singh

OTT's powerhouse performer Ishwak Singh has showcased his brilliance in 'Paatal Lok' and 'Rocket Boys'. He doesn't shout

to make an impact; instead, he breathes life into every moment. In 'Paatal Lok', his idealistic cop, Imran Ansari, became the moral centre of the entire show. In 'Rocket Boys', his portrayal of scientist Vikram Sarabhai made the iconic figure feel human rather than just a historical name. He began his journey with small roles in films like 'Ranjhanaa' and 'Veere Di Wedding', but it didn't take long for audiences to recognise his finesse as an actor through OTT.

Sunny Hinduja

Would it be an exaggeration to call Sunny Hinduja OTT's most versatile 'chameleon'? He is rarely the lead, yet he is impossible to ignore. His performances in 'Aspirants' and 'The Railway Men' perfectly demonstrate his range. In 'Aspirants', he played Sandeep Bhaiya, a UPSC aspirant whose raw and relatable struggle inspired millions. In 'The Railway Men', he portrayed a journalist uncover-



ing the truth behind the Bhopal Gas Tragedy, bringing emotional depth to a character who helped drive the narrative. Here's hoping we get to see much more of this charismatic performer.

Bhuvan Arora



As Babu in 'Raakh', actor Akash Makhija creates a disturbing world and his character refuses to leave your mind long after the credits roll

'Farzi' was as much Bhuvan Arora's show as it was Shahid Kapoor's. As the quick-witted Firoz, he emerged as one of the show's strongest pillars. Then came Amavas in the social comedy 'Dupahiya', where Bhuvan once again proved why he is becoming such a dependable performer. His work in 'TVF Pitchers' and 'Interior Cafe Night'

further highlights his versatility. His rare ability to balance comedy with emotional depth makes him a delight to watch.

Aditya Rawal



Like father, like son. Aditya Rawal is living proof that talent runs in the family. The son of veteran actor Paresh Rawal, Aditya is a remarkably consistent performer who never lets his acting falter, even when the script does. His performances in 'Bamfaad', 'Daldal' and 'Subedaar' are thoroughly compelling. Here's an actor whose range is truly impressive. Let's hope the Indian film industry utilises this rare talent to its fullest.

Naveen Kasturia

His name may not instantly ring a bell for everyone, but Naveen Kasturia's performances in 'Aspirants' and 'TVF Pitchers' showcase his quiet strength as an actor. In 'TVF Pitchers', he played Naveen Bansal, one of the friends who holds the group together with warmth, humour and authenticity. In 'Aspirants', his portrayal of Abhilash Sharma and his journey through struggle and perseverance as a UPSC aspirant became one of the emotional anchors of the series.

